Chapter 17 — JavaScript for Interviews

A JavaScript interview usually has three parts. A **coding round** asks you to solve an algorithm (a step-by-step method for solving a problem) problem (in JavaScript, so you need to know which built-ins are fast and which are traps). A **"build it yourself" round** asks you to write a utility that libraries normally give you — `debounce`, `Promise.all`, a deep clone. And a **language round** throws short snippets at you and asks "what does this print, and why?". This chapter prepares all three. It does not re-teach the language: every answer links to the section of this book that explains it fully.

What you'll learn

1. The JavaScript **DSA toolkit** (DSA = data structures and algorithms, §17.1): arrays as stacks and queues, `Map` / `Set`, sorting comparators and stability, number pitfalls (`0.1 + 0.2`, safe integers, integer division), building strings, `BigInt` — with a complexity table.
2. **Twenty-one coding patterns** — two pointers, sliding window, hashing, stack, prefix sums, intervals, heap (with a hand-written `MinHeap`, since JavaScript has none, plus two heaps for a running median and k-way merge), binary search, BFS (breadth-first search), DFS (depth-first search), dynamic programming with memoization, backtracking, linked lists, fast & slow pointers, trees, tries, topological sort and union-find, greedy, sort & search (quickselect, Dutch flag, merge sort), bit manipulation, math & geometry — each with two or three classic problems in runnable, asserted code.
3. **Implement-from-scratch classics** with tests: `debounce`, `throttle`, `curry`, `compose` / `pipe`, `memoize`, `flatten`, a `bind` polyfill (your own implementation of a built-in feature), deep clone (`structuredClone` vs manual), deep equal, an LRU (least recently used) cache, an `EventEmitter`, and `Promise.all` / `allSettled` / `race` / `any` polyfills.
4. **Fifty-three tricky questions** with real outputs: coercion (JavaScript's automatic conversion between types), equality, `typeof null`, `NaN`, hoisting and the TDZ, closures in loops, `this`, arrow vs regular functions, prototypes, classes, event-loop ordering puzzles, shallow vs deep copies, garbage collection (the engine automatically freeing memory nothing uses any more) and memory leaks.

Before you start. This chapter assumes the whole book up to Chapter 16. The tests use `node:assert/strict` and fake timers from `node:test`, explained in §16.2 and §16.5. The same patterns are solved in Python in the Python Handbook's Chapter 19: Python for Coding Interviews — handy for comparing; here we focus on what is specific to JavaScript.

All code is in `code/`. Every program checks itself with `assert` and exits with an error if any answer is wrong; outputs below are real, from Node 24.

File	Contents
`01_toolkit.mjs`	Arrays, queue, grids, Map/Set, sorting, numbers, strings, BigInt
`02_patterns_arrays.mjs`	Two pointers, sliding window, hashing, stack, prefix sums, intervals
`03_patterns_search_graphs_dp.mjs`	MinHeap, two heaps, k-way merge, binary search, BFS, DFS, DP, backtracking
`04_classics_functions.mjs`	debounce, throttle, curry, compose/pipe, memoize, flatten, bind/call
`05_classics_data.mjs`	structuredClone, deepClone, deepEqual, LRU cache, EventEmitter
`06_promise_polyfills.mjs`	all/allSettled/race/any, timeout, promisify, pool, retry
`07_qa_language.js`	Outputs for the language questions (CommonJS, sloppy mode — i.e. non-strict mode — on purpose)
`08_qa_async_and_memory.mjs`	Outputs for event-loop, strict-mode and memory questions
`09_patterns_lists_trees_tries.mjs`	Linked lists, fast & slow pointers, trees, tries (Patterns 13–16)
`10_patterns_graphs_greedy_bits_math.mjs`	Topological sort, union-find, greedy, quickselect/Dutch flag/merge sort, bits, math & geometry (Patterns 17–21)

17.1 The JavaScript DSA toolkit

What it is

DSA means *data structures and algorithms*. In an interview you have to turn an idea ("use a queue", "count with a hash map") into working code quickly. JavaScript gives you fewer ready-made structures than Java or Python — no priority queue (always hands back the smallest or most urgent item), no deque (double-ended queue: add/remove at both ends), no sorted map (keeps keys in order) — so you need to know what the built-ins really cost and how to fill the gaps.

> **Key term — hash map (hash table):** a structure that stores key → value pairs and finds a key almost instantly. A *hash function* turns the key into a number that picks a slot in an internal array, so a lookup doesn't scan every entry. JavaScript's `Map`, `Set` and plain objects are built on hash tables. Lookups are O(1) "on average" because two keys occasionally land in the same slot and need a little extra work.

Why it matters

Two JavaScript-specific traps sink otherwise-correct solutions: **hidden O(n) operations** (`shift`, `unshift`, `includes` on an array inside a loop) and **wrong answers from defaults** (`sort()` comparing numbers as text, floating-point arithmetic). Knowing the table below is the difference between an O(n) and an O(n²) solution.

> **Key term — Big-O notation (complexity):** a way to describe how the work (or memory) of an algorithm grows as the input size `n` grows, ignoring constant factors. O(1) = constant, same cost for any size; O(log n) = grows very slowly (halving each step); O(n) = linear, proportional to the input; O(n log n) = typical good sorting; O(n²) = quadratic, 10× more input means ~100× more work. Interviewers expect you to state both *time* and extra *space* complexity.

Complexity of the built-ins

Operation	Cost	Note
`arr[i]`, `arr[i] = x`, `arr.length`, `arr.at(-1)`	O(1)	
`push`, `pop`	O(1) amortized (averaged over many calls)	Use the end of an array as a **stack**
`shift`, `unshift`, `splice(i, …)`	O(n)	Every later element moves — avoid in loops
`indexOf`, `includes`, `find`, `some`	O(n)	Put values in a `Set` if you look them up repeatedly
`slice`, spread `[...a]`, `concat`, `Array.from`	O(k)	k = number of elements copied
`map`, `filter`, `reduce`, `forEach`	O(n)	Plus the callback's cost
`sort`, `toSorted`	O(n log n)	Stable (guaranteed since ES2019 — the 2019 edition of the JS standard); V8 uses TimSort (a hybrid of merge and insertion sort)
`Map` / `Set` `get`, `set`, `has`, `add`, `delete`	O(1) average	The spec only requires *sublinear* (growing slower than n) on average; engines use hash tables
Object property read/write, `in`, `Object.hasOwn`	O(1) average	
`Object.keys` / `entries`, `[...map]`	O(n)	
`str[i]`, `str.length`, `charCodeAt`	O(1)	Strings are immutable (can't be changed in place)
`str.slice`, `split`, `join`, `[...str]`	O(n)	
`JSON.stringify`, `structuredClone`	O(size)	
Heap push/pop (you write it, §17.2)	O(log n)	

Arrays as stack, queue and grid

From `code/01_toolkit.mjs`:

```
const stack = [];
stack.push(1); stack.push(2);
console.log('stack pop:', stack.pop(), 'peek:', stack.at(-1));   // O(1) at the end

const q = [1, 2, 3];
console.log('queue shift:', q.shift(), 'left:', q);             // shift is O(n)!

// A real O(1) queue: keep a head index instead of shifting
class Queue {
  #items = []; #head = 0;
  push(x) { this.#items.push(x); }
  shift() {
    if (this.#head === this.#items.length) return undefined;
    const x = this.#items[this.#head++];
    if (this.#head > 1024 && this.#head * 2 > this.#items.length) {   // compact occasionally
      this.#items = this.#items.slice(this.#head); this.#head = 0;
    }
    return x;
  }
  get size() { return this.#items.length - this.#head; }
}

// 2D grid: Array.from, NOT fill with an array (shared rows!)
const bad = new Array(2).fill(new Array(2).fill(0));
bad[0][0] = 9;
const grid = Array.from({ length: 2 }, () => new Array(2).fill(0));
grid[0][0] = 9;
```

Output:

```
stack pop: 2 peek: 1
queue shift: 1 left: [ 2, 3 ]
Queue: a 1
fill(array) shares rows: [[9,0],[9,0]]
Array.from rows are separate: [[9,0],[0,0]]
```

1. A **stack** (last in, first out) is just `push`/`pop`; peek with `at(-1)`.
2. A **queue** (first in, first out) with `shift()` is fine for small inputs, but in general each `shift` moves every element. Measured in Node 24: emptying a 10,000-element array with `shift` took 0.3 ms, a 100,000-element one 0.6 s, a 400,000-element one 10 s — quadratic growth (V8 has a shortcut for smaller arrays, not for big ones). For BFS on large graphs (a *graph* is a set of nodes joined by edges, like cities and roads) keep a **head index** — the `Queue` class above, or simply `for (let head = 0; head < queue.length; head++)` as in §17.2.
3. `fill(x)` puts the *same* value in every slot; with an array as `x`, every row is the same object. `Array.from({ length }, () => …)` calls the function once per row. (Sorting, copying and array methods are taught in Chapter 7.)

`Map` and `Set`

```
const freq = new Map();
for (const ch of 'banana') freq.set(ch, (freq.get(ch) ?? 0) + 1);
const visited = new Set();
visited.add(`${1},${2}`);                          // compound key as a string
new Set([[1, 2]]).has([1, 2]);                     // false: arrays compare by reference
const a = new Set([1, 2, 3]), b = new Set([2, 3, 4]);
a.union(b); a.intersection(b); a.difference(b);    // ES2025
```

Output:

```
freq: [ [ 'b', 1 ], [ 'a', 3 ], [ 'n', 2 ] ]
set: [ 3, 1, 2 ] has 2? true
visited has "1,2"? true | Set of arrays: false
union [ 1, 2, 3, 4 ] intersection [ 2, 3 ] difference [ 1 ]
```

- Prefer `Map` over a plain object for counting and lookups: any key type, no inherited keys like `constructor`, a real `size`, and insertion-order iteration (§8.1).
- `Map` and `Set` compare keys with **SameValueZero** (like `===`, except `NaN` equals `NaN`). Two arrays with equal contents are *different* keys, so encode coordinates as a string (`` `${r},${c}` ``) or a number (`r * cols + c`).
- The ES2025 set methods (`union`, `intersection`, `difference`, `symmetricDifference`, `isSubsetOf`, …) are in Node 22+ and all current browsers (§8.2).

Sorting: comparators and stability

```
[10, 9, 1, 100].sort();                          // compared as STRINGS
[10, 9, 1, 100].sort((x, y) => x - y);           // numeric
people.toSorted((p, r) => p.age - r.age);        // stable: ties keep input order
people.toSorted((p, r) => r.age - p.age || p.name.localeCompare(r.name));  // two keys
```

Output:

```
default sort: [ 1, 10, 100, 9 ]
numeric sort: [ 1, 9, 10, 100 ]
by age (stable): Bob Dee Ann Cid
age desc, name asc: Ann Cid Bob Dee
original untouched: Ann Bob Cid Dee
```

1. A **comparator** `(a, b) => number` returns negative if `a` goes first, positive if `b` goes first, `0` for a tie. `a - b` sorts numbers ascending; `b - a` descending.
2. **Multi-key sort**: chain comparisons with `||` — when the first difference is `0`, the second decides.
3. **Stability** means equal elements keep their original relative order (Bob before Dee, Ann before Cid above). It is guaranteed since ES2019, so you can sort by a secondary key first and the primary key second.
4. `sort` **mutates** (changes the array in place); `toSorted` (ES2023) returns a new array. In an interview, say which one you use — mutating the caller's input is a classic review comment.
5. Common mistake: returning a boolean (`(a, b) => a > b`). `true`/`false` become `1`/`0`, never negative, so the result is engine-dependent and wrong. Full details: §7.6.

Number pitfalls

```
0.1 + 0.2;                        // 0.30000000000000004
Number.MAX_SAFE_INTEGER;          // 9007199254740991 = 2**53 - 1
2 ** 53 + 1;                      // 9007199254740992 (can't be represented)
Math.trunc(-7 / 2); Math.floor(-7 / 2);   // -3 and -4
-7 % 3;                           // -1 (sign follows the dividend)
(2 ** 31 + 2) >> 1;               // -1073741823: bit operators use 32-bit ints
Math.max(...[]);                  // -Infinity
```

Output:

```
0.1 + 0.2 = 0.30000000000000004 | === 0.3? false
close(0.1+0.2, 0.3): true
MAX_SAFE_INTEGER: 9007199254740991 | 2**53 + 1 = 9007199254740992
isSafeInteger(2**53): false
7 / 2 = 3.5 | Math.trunc: 3 | -7/2 trunc: -3 floor: -4
-7 % 3 = -1 | true modulo: 2
mid without overflow worry: 5 | but >> breaks above 2**31: -1073741823
Infinity sentinels: Infinity -Infinity
Math.max(...[]) = -Infinity | parseInt("08") = 8 | Number("") = 0
NaN === NaN: false | Number.isNaN(NaN): true | isNaN("x"): true Number.isNaN("x"): false
```

Pitfall	What to do
All numbers are 64-bit floats (IEEE 754 doubles — the standard binary format for decimals, which can't store most fractions exactly), so `0.1 + 0.2 !== 0.3`	Compare with a tolerance (`Math.abs(a - b) < Number.EPSILON * scale`), or work in integers (cents, not dollars)
No integer division	`Math.trunc(a / b)` (towards zero) or `Math.floor(a / b)` (towards −∞) — they differ for negatives
`%` is a *remainder*, sign follows the left side	For array wrap-around use `((i % n) + n) % n`
Integers are exact only up to `2**53 − 1`	Check with `Number.isSafeInteger`; use `BigInt` beyond (e.g. factorials, large Fibonacci, 64-bit IDs)
Bitwise operators (``	`, `>>`, `~~`) convert to 32-bit signed ints
`Infinity` / `-Infinity`	Handy initial values for min/max; but `Math.max(...[])` is `-Infinity` and spreading a very large array (about 125,000+ elements in Node 24 on this machine — the limit depends on stack size) throws `RangeError` — use a loop or `reduce`
`isNaN('x')` coerces first	Use `Number.isNaN`

Background: §2.10 Numbers in depth.

Strings: immutable, so build with arrays

```
const parts = [];
for (let i = 0; i < 5; i++) parts.push(i);
parts.join('-');                          // '0-1-2-3-4'
'd'.charCodeAt(0) - 97;                   // 3: letter -> index 0..25
[...'hello'].reverse().join('');          // 'olleh'
```

- Strings can't be changed in place; `s[0] = 'x'` silently does nothing (throws in strict mode). To edit, convert to an array (`[...s]`), change it, `join('')`.
- Building with `+=` in a loop is fine in modern engines (V8 uses *ropes*, a tree of pieces, to avoid copying), but `push` + `join` is the clear, portable idiom (the usual way experienced programmers write it) and makes the O(n) cost obvious.
- A 26-slot counting array (`charCodeAt(0) - 97`) is faster than a `Map` for lowercase-letter problems.
- `[...s]` splits by **code point** (one Unicode character number, so emoji stay whole); `s.split('')` splits by UTF-16 code unit (16-bit pieces; some characters need two). See §6.5.

BigInt

```
const big = 2n ** 64n;                    // 18446744073709551616n, typeof 'bigint'
const factorial = (n) => (n <= 1n ? 1n : n * factorial(n - 1n));
factorial(25n);                           // 15511210043330985984000000n
7n / 2n;                                  // 3n (division truncates)
1n == 1; 1n === 1;                        // true, false
1n + 1;                                   // TypeError: can't mix BigInt and Number
JSON.stringify(1n);                       // TypeError
```

`BigInt` (ES2020) holds integers of any size — write a literal with an `n` suffix or call `BigInt(x)`. It has no fractions, no `Math.*` support, can't be mixed with numbers in arithmetic (convert explicitly), and is slower than numbers, so use it only when values may pass `2**53`.

In the interview

30-second answer — "What should I watch for when doing algorithms in JavaScript?" Arrays are stacks (`push` / `pop`); queues need a head index, not `shift`. `Map` / `Set` give O(1) lookups (string keys

for coordinates). Always pass `sort` a comparator; it mutates. Numbers are doubles: `Math.trunc` for integer division, `%` can be negative, exact only to $2^{53} - 1$ (then `BigInt`). No heap — write one.

- *Is `Array.prototype.sort` stable?* Yes, required since ES2019.
- *What does `sort()` do with no comparator?* Converts to strings and compares UTF-16 code units, with `undefined` last — so `[10, 9]` stays `[10, 9]`.
- *Why a `Map` rather than `{}` for counting?* Any key type, no prototype keys (`'constructor' in {}` is `true`), `size`, insertion order, optimised for frequent adds/removes.

Self-check

1. What is the cost of `arr.shift()`? → O(n): every remaining element moves one slot.
2. How do you create a 3×3 grid of zeros safely? → `Array.from({ length: 3 }, () => new Array(3).fill(0))`.
3. How do you sort strings alphabetically in a locale-aware way? → `arr.sort((a, b) => a.localeCompare(b))`.
4. Is `Number.isSafeInteger(2 ** 53)` true? → No — the largest safe integer is `2 ** 53 - 1`.

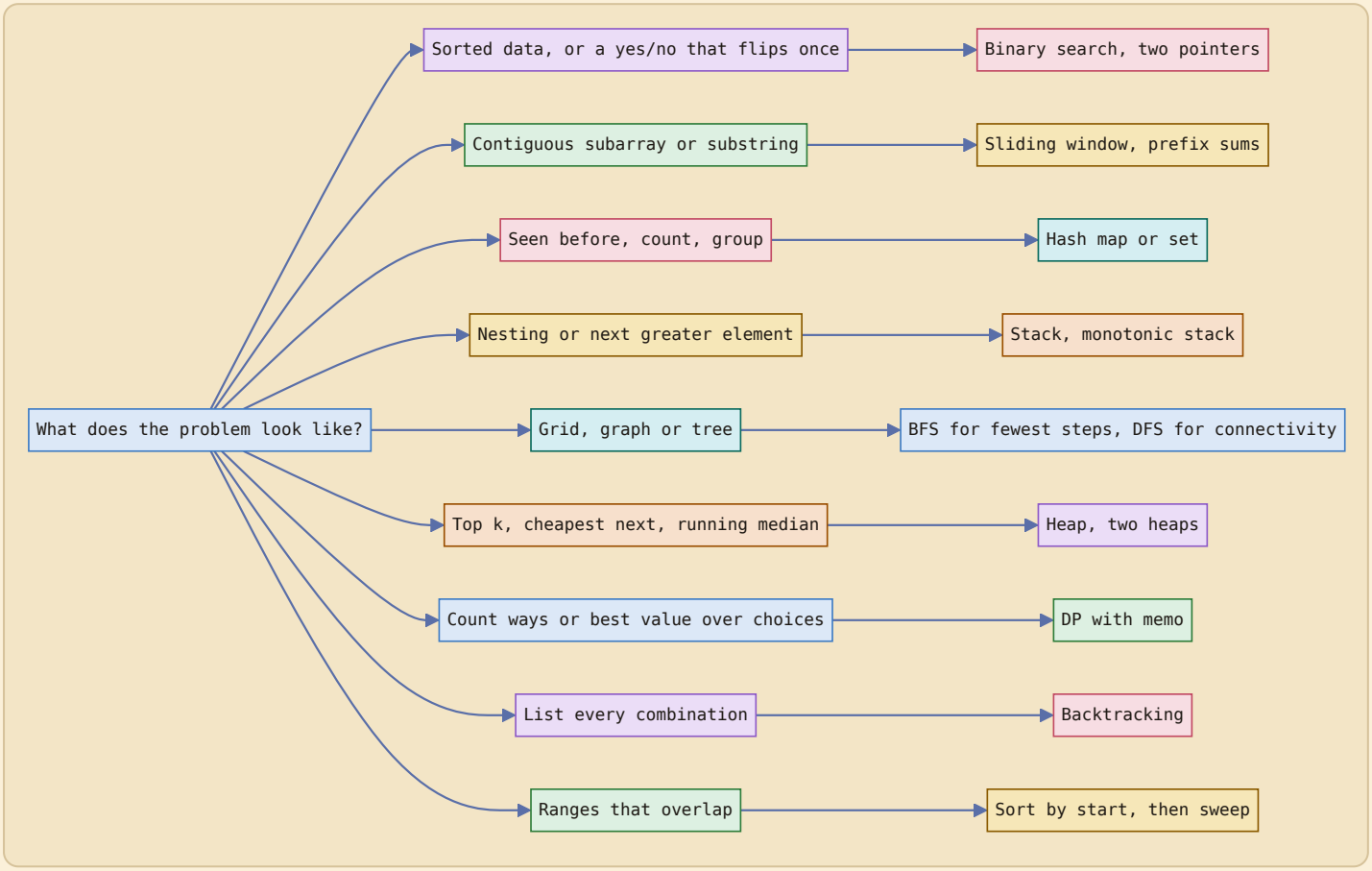
TL;DR

Stack = `push`/`pop`; queue = head index; grid = `Array.from`. `Map`/`Set` for O(1) lookups (string keys for pairs). Always give `sort` a comparator; it's stable; `toSorted` doesn't mutate. Floats: tolerance for equality, `Math.trunc` for division, safe up to $2^{53} - 1$, `BigInt` beyond.

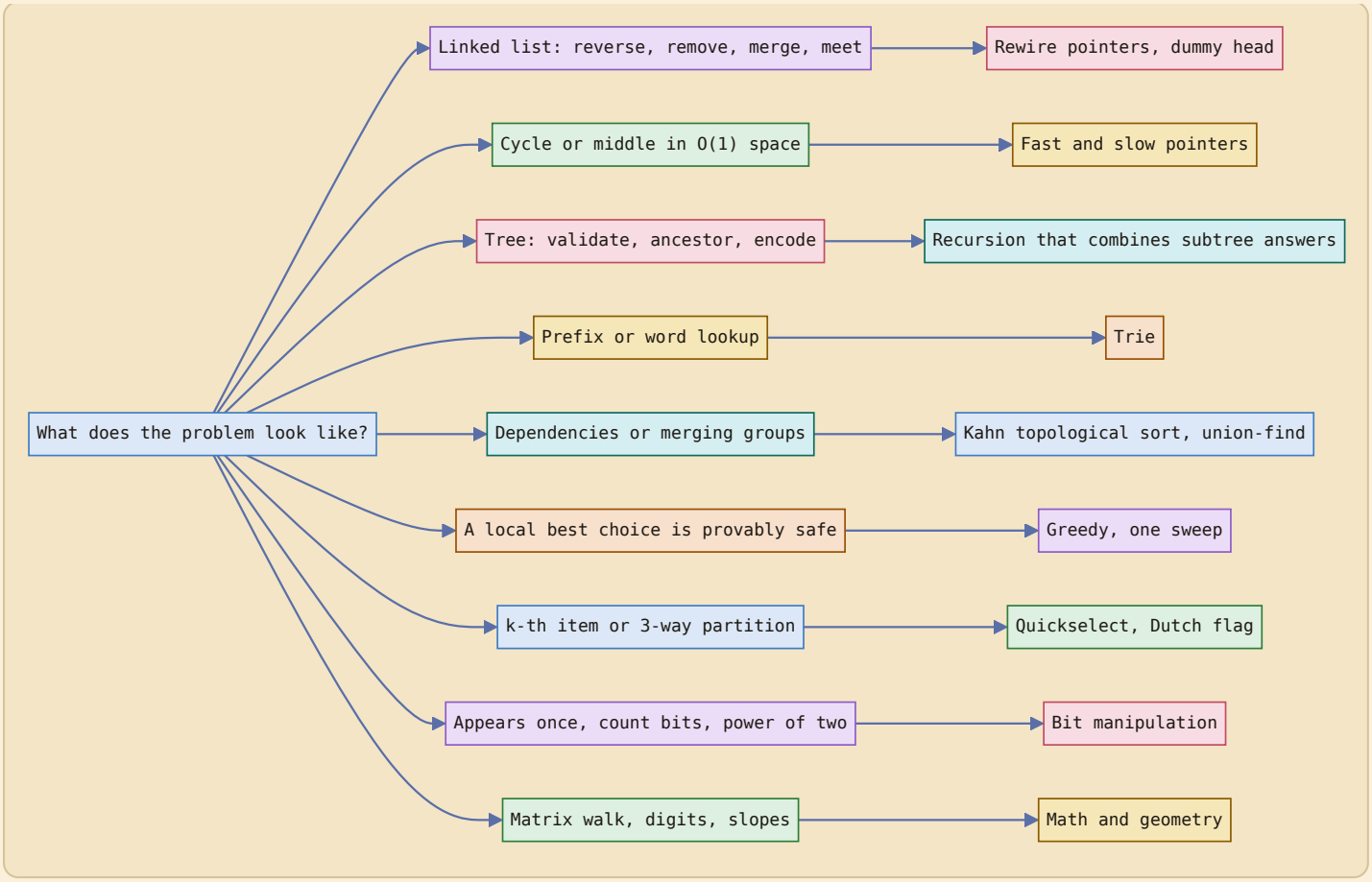
17.2 Coding patterns

What it is

A **pattern** is a reusable problem-solving shape. Most interview problems are one of about twenty patterns in disguise; recognising the pattern gives you the algorithm and its complexity almost for free. The decision chart below is a starting point, not a law.



Patterns 13–21 cover the remaining shapes — specific data structures and a few algorithm families:



For each pattern: the idea, when it applies, the code (with asserts), and its cost. The full programs are `code/02_patterns_arrays.mjs`, `code/03_patterns_search_graphs_dp.mjs`, `code/09_patterns_lists_trees_tries.mjs` and `code/10_patterns_graphs_greedy_bits_math.mjs`.

Pattern 1 — Two pointers

Idea: two indexes move towards each other (or in the same direction) so each element is looked at once. **Signal:** sorted array, pairs, palindromes (text that reads the same backwards), in-place partitioning (rearranging inside the same array, no copy). **Cost:** O(n) time, O(1) space.

```
function pairSum(sorted, target) {
  let lo = 0, hi = sorted.length - 1;
  while (lo < hi) {
    const s = sorted[lo] + sorted[hi];
    if (s === target) return [lo, hi];
    if (s < target) lo++; else hi--;      // too small: need a bigger left value
  }
  return null;
}
assert.deepEqual(pairSum([1, 3, 4, 6, 9], 12), [1, 4]);

function isPalindrome(s) {
  const t = s.toLowerCase().replace(/[^a-z0-9]/g, '');
  for (let i = 0, j = t.length - 1; i < j; i++, j--) if (t[i] !== t[j]) return false;
  return true;
}
assert.equal(isPalindrome('A man, a plan, a canal: Panama'), true);
```

Why it's correct: if the sum is too small, the smallest element can't be part of any answer with a *smaller* partner, so discarding it (`lo++`) loses nothing.

Pattern 2 — Sliding window

Idea: keep a window `[start, end]` over a sequence; grow the end, shrink the start when a rule breaks. **Signal:** "longest/shortest/max-sum **contiguous** (neighbouring, with no gaps) subarray or substring". **Cost:**

O(n) — each index enters and leaves the window once.

```
function longestUnique(s) {
  const last = new Map();                  // char -> last index seen
  let start = 0, best = 0;
  for (let end = 0; end < s.length; end++) {
    const ch = s[end];
    if (last.has(ch) && last.get(ch) >= start) start = last.get(ch) + 1;   // shrink
    last.set(ch, end);
    best = Math.max(best, end - start + 1);
  }
  return best;
}
assert.equal(longestUnique('abcabcbb'), 3);

function maxSumK(nums, k) {                // fixed-size window: add the new, drop the old
  let sum = 0;
  for (let i = 0; i < k; i++) sum += nums[i];
  let best = sum;
  for (let i = k; i < nums.length; i++) { sum += nums[i] - nums[i - k]; best = Math.max(best, sum); }
  return best;
}
assert.equal(maxSumK([2, 1, 5, 1, 3, 2], 3), 9);
```

Pattern 3 — Hashing

Idea: trade memory for time — remember what you've seen in a `Map`/`Set` so a later lookup is O(1). **Signal:** "find a pair/duplicate", "group by", "count". **Cost:** O(n) time, O(n) space.

```
function twoSum(nums, target) {
  const indexOf = new Map();
  for (let i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
    const need = target - nums[i];
    if (indexOf.has(need)) return [indexOf.get(need), i];   // check BEFORE inserting
    indexOf.set(nums[i], i);
  }
  return null;
}
assert.deepEqual(twoSum([2, 7, 11, 15], 9), [0, 1]);
assert.deepEqual(twoSum([3, 3], 6), [0, 1]);

function groupAnagrams(words) {
  const groups = new Map();
  for (const w of words) {
    const key = [...w].sort().join('');      // canonical form = the hash key
    if (!groups.has(key)) groups.set(key, []);
    groups.get(key).push(w);
  }
  return [...groups.values()];
}
```

Checking before inserting is what makes `[3, 3]` work: the first `3` is not paired with itself. (Anagrams are words with the same letters in a different order; sorting the letters gives every anagram the same *canonical* key.) (`Map.groupBy` from §8.7 does the grouping step in one call.)

Pattern 4 — Stack (and monotonic stack)

Idea: a stack remembers "things still open" — brackets, unfinished elements. A **monotonic stack** keeps its contents increasing or decreasing and answers "next greater/smaller element" questions. **Cost:** O(n) — every index is pushed and popped at most once.

```
function isBalanced(s) {
  const pairs = { ')': '(', ']': '[', '}': '{' };
  const st = [];
  for (const ch of s) {
    if ('([{'.includes(ch)) st.push(ch);
    else if (ch in pairs) { if (st.pop() !== pairs[ch]) return false; }
  }
  return st.length === 0;                  // leftovers = unclosed brackets
}

function dailyTemperatures(t) {            // days until a warmer day
  const ans = new Array(t.length).fill(0);
  const st = [];                           // indices whose temperatures are decreasing
  for (let i = 0; i < t.length; i++) {
    while (st.length && t[i] > t[st.at(-1)]) { const j = st.pop(); ans[j] = i - j; }
    st.push(i);
  }
  return ans;
}
assert.deepEqual(dailyTemperatures([73, 74, 75, 71, 69, 72, 76, 73]), [1, 1, 4, 2, 1, 1, 0, 0]);
```

Pattern 5 — Prefix sums

Idea: precompute running totals `p[i] = nums[0] + … + nums[i-1]`; then any range sum is one subtraction. Combined with a hash map it counts subarrays with a given sum, even with negative numbers (where a sliding window fails). **Cost:** O(n) setup, O(1) per query.

```
function prefix(nums) {
  const p = [0];
  for (const x of nums) p.push(p.at(-1) + x);
  return (i, j) => p[j + 1] - p[i];        // sum of nums[i..j] inclusive
}
assert.equal(prefix([3, 1, 4, 1, 5, 9])(2, 5), 19);

function subarraySum(nums, k) {            // how many subarrays sum to k?
  const count = new Map([[0, 1]]);         // the empty prefix
  let sum = 0, total = 0;
  for (const x of nums) {
    sum += x;
    total += count.get(sum - k) ?? 0;      // earlier prefixes that leave exactly k
    count.set(sum, (count.get(sum) ?? 0) + 1);
  }
  return total;
}
assert.equal(subarraySum([1, -1, 0], 0), 3);
```

Pattern 6 — Intervals

Idea: sort by start, then sweep once, merging or counting overlaps. **Signal:** meetings, bookings, ranges. **Cost:** O(n log n) for the sort.

```
function mergeIntervals(intervals) {
  const sorted = intervals.toSorted((a, b) => a[0] - b[0]);   // don't mutate the input
  const out = [];
  for (const [s, e] of sorted) {
    const last = out.at(-1);
    if (last && s <= last[1]) last[1] = Math.max(last[1], e);   // overlap: extend
    else out.push([s, e]);
  }
  return out;
}
assert.deepEqual(mergeIntervals([[8, 10], [1, 3], [2, 6], [15, 18]]), [[1, 6], [8, 10], [15, 18]]);

function minRooms(meetings) {              // sweep line: sorted starts vs sorted ends
  const starts = meetings.map(m => m[0]).sort((a, b) => a - b);
  const ends = meetings.map(m => m[1]).sort((a, b) => a - b);
  let rooms = 0, best = 0, j = 0;
  for (const s of starts) {
    while (ends[j] <= s) { j++; rooms--; }  // a meeting ending at s frees its room
    rooms++; best = Math.max(best, rooms);
  }
  return best;
}
assert.equal(minRooms([[0, 30], [5, 10], [15, 20]]), 2);
```

Output of the array-patterns program:

```
pairSum [ 1, 4 ] | longestUnique("abcabcbb") 3
twoSum [ 0, 1 ] | groupAnagrams [["eat","tea","ate"],["tan","nat"],["bat"]]
dailyTemperatures 1,1,4,2,1,1,0,0
subarraySum([1,1,1],2) 2 | merge [[1,6],[8,10],[15,18]] | rooms 2
all array-pattern asserts passed
```

Pattern 7 — Heap (write your own `MinHeap`)

What it is: a **binary heap** is a complete binary tree (a tree where each node has at most two children and every level is full except possibly the last, filled from the left — see Pattern 15) stored in an array where every parent is ≤ its children (a *min*-heap). The smallest item is always at index 0. For index `i`, the children are `2i+1` and `2i+2`, the parent is `(i−1)>>1`. **Signal:** "k largest/smallest", "merge k sorted lists", "median (middle value when sorted) of a stream", "always process the cheapest next" (Dijkstra's shortest-path algorithm, scheduling). **Cost:** `push`/`pop` O(log n), `peek` O(1).

JavaScript has **no built-in priority queue**, so interviewers expect you to write one (or at least describe it). Twenty-five lines are enough:

```
export class MinHeap {
  #a = [];
  #less;
  constructor(less = (x, y) => x < y) { this.#less = less; }   // custom ordering
  get size() { return this.#a.length; }
  peek() { return this.#a[0]; }
  push(x) {                                    // add at the end, sift UP
    const a = this.#a; a.push(x);
    let i = a.length - 1;
    while (i > 0) {
      const p = (i - 1) >> 1;
      if (!this.#less(a[i], a[p])) break;
      [a[i], a[p]] = [a[p], a[i]]; i = p;
    }
  }
  pop() {                                      // move the last to the root, sift DOWN
    const a = this.#a;
    if (a.length === 0) return undefined;
    const top = a[0], last = a.pop();
    if (a.length) {
      a[0] = last;
      let i = 0;
      for (;;) {
        const l = 2 * i + 1, r = l + 1;
        let m = i;
        if (l < a.length && this.#less(a[l], a[m])) m = l;
        if (r < a.length && this.#less(a[r], a[m])) m = r;
        if (m === i) break;
        [a[i], a[m]] = [a[m], a[i]]; i = m;
      }
    }
    return top;
  }
}

function kLargest(nums, k) {                   // min-heap of size k: O(n log k)
  const heap = new MinHeap();
  for (const x of nums) { heap.push(x); if (heap.size > k) heap.pop(); }
  const out = []; while (heap.size) out.push(heap.pop());
  return out.reverse();
}
assert.deepEqual(kLargest([3, 2, 1, 5, 6, 4], 2), [6, 5]);
```

The `less` parameter makes it a general **priority queue**: pass `(x, y) => x > y` for a max-heap, or compare a field. Dijkstra's shortest paths uses `[distance, node]` pairs:

```
function dijkstra(graph, src) {
  const dist = new Map([[src, 0]]);
  const pq = new MinHeap((x, y) => x[0] < y[0]);   // [distance, node]
  pq.push([0, src]);
  while (pq.size) {
    const [d, u] = pq.pop();
    if (d > dist.get(u)) continue;                  // stale entry: a shorter path was found
    for (const [v, w] of graph[u] ?? []) {
      const nd = d + w;
      if (nd < (dist.get(v) ?? Infinity)) { dist.set(v, nd); pq.push([nd, v]); }
    }
  }
  return Object.fromEntries(dist);
}
const roads = { A: [['B', 4], ['C', 1]], C: [['B', 2], ['D', 7]], B: [['D', 1]] };
assert.deepEqual(dijkstra(roads, 'A'), { A: 0, C: 1, B: 3, D: 4 });
```

Two heaps: the running median. To report the median of a stream after every new number, keep the smaller half in a **max-heap** (`low`) and the larger half in a **min-heap** (`high`), with `low` holding the same number of items or one more. The median is then `low`'s top, or the average of both tops. Each `add` is O(log n); `median` is O(1).

```
class MedianFinder {
  #low = new MinHeap((x, y) => x > y);        // max-heap: the smaller half
  #high = new MinHeap();                      // min-heap: the larger half
  add(x) {
    if (this.#low.size === 0 || x <= this.#low.peek()) this.#low.push(x); else this.#high.push(x);
    if (this.#low.size > this.#high.size + 1) this.#high.push(this.#low.pop());   // rebalance
    else if (this.#high.size > this.#low.size) this.#low.push(this.#high.pop());
  }
  median() {
    return this.#low.size > this.#high.size ? this.#low.peek() : (this.#low.peek() + this.#high.peek()) / 2;
  }
}
const mf = new MedianFinder();
assert.deepEqual([5, 15, 1, 3].map(x => { mf.add(x); return mf.median(); }), [5, 10, 5, 4]);
```

k-way merge. To merge k sorted lists, keep one "front" item per list in a min-heap; pop the smallest, then push the next item from the same list. With N items in total the cost is O(N log k) — better than concatenating and sorting (O(N log N)) when k is small.

```
function mergeKSorted(lists) {
  const pq = new MinHeap((x, y) => x[0] < y[0]);    // [value, list index, position]
  lists.forEach((l, i) => { if (l.length) pq.push([l[0], i, 0]); });
  const out = [];
  while (pq.size) {
    const [v, i, j] = pq.pop();
    out.push(v);
    if (j + 1 < lists[i].length) pq.push([lists[i][j + 1], i, j + 1]);   // refill from the same list
  }
  return out;
}
assert.deepEqual(mergeKSorted([[1, 4, 7], [2, 5, 8], [0, 3, 6, 9], []]), [0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9]);
```

Shortcut worth knowing: if you only need to sort once, `toSorted` is simpler and also O(n log n). A heap wins when items arrive over time or you need only the top k.

Pattern 8 — Binary search

Idea: halve the search space each step. **Signal:** sorted data, or a yes/no condition that flips once as a number grows ("the smallest speed that works"). **Cost:** O(log n) steps.

```
function lowerBound(a, target) {            // first index with a[i] >= target
  let lo = 0, hi = a.length;                // half-open range [lo, hi)
  while (lo < hi) {
    const mid = lo + Math.floor((hi - lo) / 2);
    if (a[mid] < target) lo = mid + 1; else hi = mid;
  }
  return lo;                                 // a.length if every value is smaller
}
assert.equal(lowerBound([1, 3, 3, 5, 8], 3), 1);
assert.equal(lowerBound([1, 3, 3, 5, 8], 4), 3);

function minEatingSpeed(piles, hours) {     // binary search on the ANSWER
  let lo = 1, hi = Math.max(...piles);
  const ok = (k) => piles.reduce((t, p) => t + Math.ceil(p / k), 0) <= hours;
  while (lo < hi) { const mid = (lo + hi) >> 1; if (ok(mid)) hi = mid; else lo = mid + 1; }
  return lo;
}
assert.equal(minEatingSpeed([3, 6, 7, 11], 8), 4);
```

Use one template (half-open `[lo, hi)`, `lo < hi`, `hi = mid`) and you avoid the off-by-one bugs (being wrong by exactly one index) that make binary search famous. JavaScript has no `bisect` built-in; `indexOf` / `findIndex` are linear.

Pattern 9 — Breadth-first search (BFS)

Idea: explore in rings — all nodes 1 step away, then 2 steps, … using a queue. The first time you reach a node is by a **shortest path** (in steps). **Signal:** "minimum number of moves", unweighted shortest path,

level-order traversal. **Cost:** O(V + E) (V = number of vertices/nodes, E = number of edges; for a grid, O(rows × cols)).

```
function shortestPath(grid, [sr, sc], [tr, tc]) {
  const R = grid.length, C = grid[0].length;
  const dist = Array.from({ length: R }, () => new Array(C).fill(-1));   // -1 = unvisited
  const queue = [[sr, sc]]; dist[sr][sc] = 0;
  for (let head = 0; head < queue.length; head++) {       // index instead of shift()
    const [r, c] = queue[head];
    if (r === tr && c === tc) return dist[r][c];
    for (const [dr, dc] of [[1, 0], [-1, 0], [0, 1], [0, -1]]) {
      const nr = r + dr, nc = c + dc;
      if (nr >= 0 && nr < R && nc >= 0 && nc < C && grid[nr][nc] !== '#' && dist[nr][nc] === -1) {
        dist[nr][nc] = dist[r][c] + 1; queue.push([nr, nc]);   // mark when ENQUEUED
      }
    }
  }
  return -1;
}
assert.equal(shortestPath(['..#.', '..#.', '....'], [0, 0], [0, 3]), 7);
```

Mark a cell visited when you **enqueue** it (add it to the queue), not when you dequeue it (take it out) — otherwise the same cell enters the queue many times.

Pattern 10 — Depth-first search (DFS)

Idea: go as deep as possible, then back up. **Signal:** connectivity ("number of islands"), cycle detection, topological order (an ordering where every dependency comes first — Pattern 17), exploring every path. **Cost:** O(V + E).

```
function numIslands(rows) {
  const g = rows.map(r => [...r]);          // copy: don't destroy the caller's grid
  let count = 0;
  for (let r = 0; r < g.length; r++) for (let c = 0; c < g[0].length; c++) {
    if (g[r][c] !== '1') continue;
    count++;
    const st = [[r, c]]; g[r][c] = '0';      // explicit stack = iterative DFS
    while (st.length) {
      const [x, y] = st.pop();
      for (const [nx, ny] of [[x + 1, y], [x - 1, y], [x, y + 1], [x, y - 1]]) {
        if (g[nx]?.[ny] === '1') { g[nx][ny] = '0'; st.push([nx, ny]); }   // ?. handles edges
      }
    }
  }
  return count;
}
assert.equal(numIslands(['11000', '11000', '00100', '00011']), 3);

function topoSort(n, edges) {               // recursive DFS with three colours
  const adj = Array.from({ length: n }, () => []);
  for (const [u, v] of edges) adj[u].push(v);
  const state = new Array(n).fill(0);       // 0 new, 1 on the current path, 2 done
  const order = [];
  const visit = (u) => {
    if (state[u] === 1) throw new Error('cycle');
    if (state[u] === 2) return;
    state[u] = 1;
    for (const v of adj[u]) visit(v);
    state[u] = 2; order.push(u);            // post-order
  };
  for (let u = 0; u < n; u++) visit(u);
  return order.reverse();
}
assert.deepEqual(topoSort(4, [[0, 1], [0, 2], [1, 3], [2, 3]]), [0, 2, 1, 3]);
```

JavaScript-specific: recursion depth is limited (roughly ten thousand frames — one stack frame per active call — in V8, depending on frame size), and there's no tail-call optimisation (reusing the

current frame when a function's very last action is a call) in V8. For inputs that can be deep — a 1000×1000 grid of land — use the iterative version with an explicit stack.

Pattern 11 — Dynamic programming with memoization

What it is: **dynamic programming (DP)** solves a problem by combining answers to smaller versions of the same problem, storing each answer so it is computed once. **Top-down** = recursion + a cache (**memoization**); **bottom-up** = fill a table in order. **Signal:** "count the ways", "minimum cost", "longest …", when the plain recursion repeats the same calls. **Cost:** (number of states) × (work per state).

```
function climb(n, memo = new Map()) {       // ways to climb n stairs taking 1 or 2 steps
  if (n <= 1) return 1;
  if (memo.has(n)) return memo.get(n);
  const v = climb(n - 1, memo) + climb(n - 2, memo);
  memo.set(n, v);
  return v;
}
assert.equal(climb(70), 308061521170129);   // exact: below 2**53
assert.equal(Number.isSafeInteger(climb(80)), false);   // too big: use BigInt

function coinChange(coins, amount) {        // bottom-up: fewest coins for each amount
  const dp = new Array(amount + 1).fill(Infinity); dp[0] = 0;
  for (let a = 1; a <= amount; a++)
    for (const c of coins) if (c <= a) dp[a] = Math.min(dp[a], dp[a - c] + 1);
  return dp[amount] === Infinity ? -1 : dp[amount];
}
assert.equal(coinChange([1, 2, 5], 11), 3);

function lcs(a, b) {                        // longest common subsequence: 2D table
  const dp = Array.from({ length: a.length + 1 }, () => new Array(b.length + 1).fill(0));
  for (let i = 1; i <= a.length; i++) for (let j = 1; j <= b.length; j++)
    dp[i][j] = a[i - 1] === b[j - 1] ? dp[i - 1][j - 1] + 1 : Math.max(dp[i - 1][j], dp[i][j - 1]);
  return dp[a.length][b.length];
}
assert.equal(lcs('abcde', 'ace'), 3);
```

Without the memo, `climb(70)` would make about 6 × 10^{14} calls; with it, about 140. Note the JavaScript twist: the answer for 80 stairs is larger than `2**53`, so a real solution would switch to `BigInt` (§17.1). For multi-argument states, use a string key (`` `${i},${j}` ``) or a 2D array.

Pattern 12 — Backtracking

Idea: build a solution one choice at a time; after exploring a choice, **undo** it and try the next (choose → explore → un-choose). Prune (stop exploring) branches that can't succeed. **Signal:** "list all subsets/permutations (orderings)/combinations", puzzles (N-Queens, Sudoku). **Cost:** exponential (doubling or worse with every extra item) — 2^n subsets, $n!$ permutations — so inputs are small.

```
function subsets(nums) {
  const out = [], cur = [];
  const go = (i) => {
    if (i === nums.length) { out.push([...cur]); return; }   // COPY the current path
    cur.push(nums[i]); go(i + 1); cur.pop();                 // choose, explore, un-choose
    go(i + 1);                                               // skip nums[i]
  };
  go(0);
  return out;
}
assert.deepEqual(subsets([1, 2]), [[1, 2], [1], [2], []]);

function nQueens(n) {                        // pruning with Sets of attacked lines
  const cols = new Set(), d1 = new Set(), d2 = new Set();
  let count = 0;
  const place = (r) => {
    if (r === n) { count++; return; }
    for (let c = 0; c < n; c++) {
      if (cols.has(c) || d1.has(r - c) || d2.has(r + c)) continue;
      cols.add(c); d1.add(r - c); d2.add(r + c);
      place(r + 1);
      cols.delete(c); d1.delete(r - c); d2.delete(r + c);
    }
  };
  place(0);
  return count;
}
assert.equal(nQueens(8), 92);
```

The most common JavaScript bug here is `out.push(cur)` without copying: every entry would be the *same* array, which ends up empty. (`permutations` with a `used` array is in the code file.)

Output of the search/graph/DP program:

```
heap drain 1,2,3,5,8,9 | kLargest [ 6, 5 ] | dijkstra {"A":0,"B":3,"C":1,"D":4}
running medians 5,10,5,4 | k-way merge 0,1,2,3,4,5,6,7,8,9
lowerBound 4 -> 3 | minEatingSpeed 4
maze steps 7 | islands 3 | topo 0,2,1,3
climb(70) 308061521170129 | climb(80) safe? false | coinChange 11 3 | lcs 3
subsets [[1,2],[1],[2],[]] | perms of 3: 6 | 8-queens 92
all search/graph/DP asserts passed
```

Pattern 13 — Linked lists

What it is: a **linked list** is a chain of nodes; each node holds a value and a `next` reference to the following node (`null` at the end). Unlike an array there is no index: reaching the k-th node means walking k steps, but inserting or removing a node you already hold is O(1) — you only rewire references. JavaScript has no built-in linked list, so problems hand you a `{ val, next }` shape. **Signal:**

"reverse", "remove the k-th from the end", "merge", "where do two lists meet". **Cost:** usually O(n) time, O(1) extra space.

```
class ListNode { constructor(val, next = null) { this.val = val; this.next = next; } }

function reverseList(head) {                // flip every arrow while walking
  let prev = null, cur = head;
  while (cur) {
    const next = cur.next;                  // save before overwriting
    cur.next = prev;
    prev = cur; cur = next;
  }
  return prev;                              // the old tail is the new head
}
assert.deepEqual(toArray(reverseList(fromArray([1, 2, 3, 4]))), [4, 3, 2, 1]);

function removeKthFromEnd(head, k) {        // one pass: `lead` runs k nodes ahead
  const dummy = new ListNode(0, head);      // dummy head: removing the head needs no special case
  let lead = dummy, trail = dummy;
  for (let i = 0; i < k; i++) lead = lead.next;
  while (lead.next) { lead = lead.next; trail = trail.next; }
  trail.next = trail.next.next;             // trail sits just before the node to remove
  return dummy.next;
}
assert.deepEqual(toArray(removeKthFromEnd(fromArray([1, 2, 3, 4, 5]), 2)), [1, 2, 3, 5]);

function intersection(a, b) {               // first node shared by two lists, or null
  let p = a, q = b;
  while (p !== q) { p = p ? p.next : b; q = q ? q.next : a; }
  return p;
}
```

Why `intersection` works: pointer `p` walks list A then list B, `q` walks B then A. Both travel `lenA + lenB` steps, so they line up and reach the shared node at the same moment — or both reach `null` together if there is none. It compares **nodes** with `!==`, not values: two lists that merely contain equal numbers do not intersect. The **dummy head** trick (a fake node before the real head) appears in almost every list problem because it removes the "what if I change the head?" branch. `fromArray`/`toArray` helpers are in the code file.

Pattern 14 — Fast & slow pointers

Idea: two pointers move through a sequence at different speeds — slow one step, fast two steps. If the sequence loops, fast eventually laps slow and they meet; if it ends, fast reaches the end when slow is halfway. **Signal:** "is there a cycle / where does it start", "middle of a list", any "does repeating this step loop forever?" question. **Cost:** O(n) time, **O(1) space** — the point, since a `Set` of visited nodes would also work but costs O(n).

```
function cycleStart(head) {                 // Floyd's algorithm
  let slow = head, fast = head;
  while (fast && fast.next) {
    slow = slow.next; fast = fast.next.next;
    if (slow === fast) {                    // met inside the loop
      let p = head;
      while (p !== slow) { p = p.next; slow = slow.next; }
      return p;                             // they meet again at the loop's first node
    }
  }
  return null;                              // fast fell off the end: no cycle
}

function middle(head) {                     // second middle for even lengths
  let slow = head, fast = head;
  while (fast && fast.next) { slow = slow.next; fast = fast.next.next; }
  return slow;
}
assert.equal(middle(fromArray([1, 2, 3, 4, 5])).val, 3);

function isHappy(n) {                       // n -> sum of squared digits; reaches 1 or loops
  const next = (x) => { let s = 0; while (x > 0) { const d = x % 10; s += d * d; x = Math.floor(x / 10); } return
s; };
  let slow = n, fast = next(n);
  while (fast !== 1 && slow !== fast) { slow = next(slow); fast = next(next(fast)); }
  return fast === 1;
}
assert.equal(isHappy(19), true);            // 19 -> 82 -> 68 -> 100 -> 1
assert.equal(isHappy(2), false);
```

Why the second phase finds the loop's start: say the start is `a` steps from the head and the pointers meet `b` steps into a loop of length `c`. Fast walked twice as far, so `2(a + b) = a + b + k·c` for some whole number `k`, which gives `a = k·c − b`. Walking `a` more steps from the meeting point therefore lands exactly on the loop's start — the same place a pointer starting at the head reaches after `a` steps. `isHappy` shows the pattern without any list: the "next" function defines an implicit chain.

Pattern 15 — Trees

What it is: a **binary tree** is a set of nodes where each node has at most two children (`left`, `right`); the top node is the **root**, nodes without children are **leaves**. A **binary search tree (BST)** adds a rule: every value in the left subtree is smaller than the node, every value in the right subtree larger. Most tree answers are a short recursive function that asks each subtree a question and combines the two answers. **Signal:** "validate", "lowest common ancestor", "path sum", "rebuild / encode a tree".

Cost: O(n) time, O(h) stack for a tree of height `h` (h = log n when balanced — both sides of every node about equally deep — n when it degenerates into a line).

```
class TreeNode { constructor(val, left = null, right = null) { this.val = val; this.left = left; this.right = right; } }

function isValidBST(node, lo = -Infinity, hi = Infinity) {   // pass the allowed range DOWN
  if (!node) return true;
  if (node.val <= lo || node.val >= hi) return false;
  return isValidBST(node.left, lo, node.val) && isValidBST(node.right, node.val, hi);
}
assert.equal(isValidBST(fromLevels([5, 1, 7, null, null, 4, 8])), false);   // 4 is right of 5

function lca(root, p, q) {                  // lowest common ancestor of values p and q
  if (!root || root.val === p || root.val === q) return root;
  const left = lca(root.left, p, q), right = lca(root.right, p, q);
  return left && right ? root : left ?? right;   // found on both sides: this node splits them
}
const family = fromLevels([3, 5, 1, 6, 2, 0, 8, null, null, 7, 4]);
assert.equal(lca(family, 7, 4).val, 2);

function serialize(root) {                  // preorder, '#' marks an empty child
  const out = [];
  const go = (n) => { if (!n) { out.push('#'); return; } out.push(n.val); go(n.left); go(n.right); };
  go(root);
  return out.join(',');
}
function deserialize(text) {
  const tokens = text.split(',');
  let i = 0;
  const go = () => {
    const t = tokens[i++];
    if (t === '#') return null;
    const node = new TreeNode(Number(t));
    node.left = go(); node.right = go();      // same order as serialize
    return node;
  };
  return go();
}
assert.equal(serialize(fromLevels([1, 2, 3, null, null, 4, 5])), '1,2,#,#,3,4,#,#,5,#,#');
```

The classic BST bug is comparing a node only with its parent: in `[5, 1, 7, null, null, 4, 8]`, 4 is a correct left child of 7 but sits in 5's *right* subtree, so the tree is invalid. Passing the range `(lo, hi)` down catches it. Serialization (turning the tree into a string) works because preorder (visit a node, then its left subtree, then its right) plus explicit `#` markers fixes the shape: the reader always knows whether the next token is a left child, a right child or an empty slot. (`fromLevels`, which builds a tree from a level-order array with `null` gaps, is in the code file; deep, unbalanced trees hit the recursion-depth limit from Pattern 10 — switch to an explicit stack.)

Pattern 16 — Tries

What it is: a **trie** (prefix tree, pronounced "try") stores strings one character per level; words that share a prefix share the same path from the root, and a flag marks "a word ends here". Looking up a word or prefix of length `L` costs O(L), no matter how many words are stored. **Signal:** "autocomplete",

"starts with", "search with a wildcard", "find many words in a grid". **Cost:** O(L) per insert/search; memory O(total characters).

```
class Trie {
  #root = { next: new Map(), end: false };
  insert(word) {
    let n = this.#root;
    for (const ch of word) {
      if (!n.next.has(ch)) n.next.set(ch, { next: new Map(), end: false });
      n = n.next.get(ch);
    }
    n.end = true;                          // "a word finishes here"
  }
  #walk(prefix) {
    let n = this.#root;
    for (const ch of prefix) { n = n.next.get(ch); if (!n) return null; }
    return n;
  }
  search(word) { return this.#walk(word)?.end === true; }
  startsWith(prefix) { return this.#walk(prefix) !== null; }
  match(pattern) {                         // '.' matches any one letter
    const go = (n, i) => {
      if (i === pattern.length) return n.end;
      if (pattern[i] !== '.') { const nx = n.next.get(pattern[i]); return nx ? go(nx, i + 1) : false; }
      for (const nx of n.next.values()) if (go(nx, i + 1)) return true;   // try every branch
      return false;
    };
    return go(this.#root, 0);
  }
}
// words: car, card, care, cat, dog
assert.equal(trie.search('ca'), false);      // a prefix, not a stored word
assert.equal(trie.match('c.r.'), true);      // card, care
```

The third classic, **word search on a board** (find every listed word that can be traced through neighbouring cells, each cell used once per word), combines a trie with Pattern 12's backtracking: one DFS from each cell walks the board and the trie together, and stops as soon as the letters so far are not a prefix of any word. That prune is what makes it fast compared with searching for each word separately.

```
function findWords(board, words) {
  const root = {};
  for (const w of words) { let n = root; for (const ch of w) n = n[ch] ??= {}; n.$word = w; }
  const grid = board.map(row => [...row]);   // copy: cells are marked while exploring
  const R = grid.length, C = grid[0].length, found = [];
  const dfs = (r, c, node) => {
    const ch = grid[r][c], next = node[ch];
    if (!next) return;                       // no word continues this way: prune
    if (next.$word) { found.push(next.$word); delete next.$word; }   // report once
    grid[r][c] = '#';                        // choose
    for (const [dr, dc] of [[1, 0], [-1, 0], [0, 1], [0, -1]]) {
      const nr = r + dr, nc = c + dc;
      if (nr >= 0 && nr < R && nc >= 0 && nc < C && grid[nr][nc] !== '#') dfs(nr, nc, next);
    }
    grid[r][c] = ch;                         // un-choose
  };
  for (let r = 0; r < R; r++) for (let c = 0; c < C; c++) dfs(r, c, root);
  return found.sort();
}
assert.deepEqual(findWords(['cats', 'ored', 'waxy'], ['cat', 'cats', 'car', 'core', 'cow', 'dog', 'red', 'wax',
'tax']),
  ['car', 'cat', 'cats', 'core', 'cow', 'red', 'wax']);
```

JavaScript notes: a `Map` per node is the clean choice; a plain object (`n[ch] ??= {}`) is shorter, but then a stored key such as `$word` must never collide with a letter. For lowercase-only input, a 26-slot array per node is the fastest variant (§17.1).

Output of the list/tree/trie program:

```
reverse 4,3,2,1 | remove 2nd from end 1,2,3,5 | intersection at 8
cycle starts at 3 | middle of 1..4 3 | happy 19? true | happy 2? false
validBST true false | lca(7,4) 2 | serialized 1,2,#,#,3,4,#,#,5,#,#
trie search car true | prefix ca true | match c.r. true | board words car,cat,cats,core,cow,red,wax
all list/tree/trie asserts passed
```

Pattern 17 — Topological sort and union-find

What it is: two graph tools that plain BFS/DFS (Patterns 9–10) don't cover directly. A **topological order** lists the nodes of a directed graph (one whose edges point one way, like "A before B") so every edge goes from earlier to later ("take prerequisites first"); it exists only if the graph has no cycle. **Kahn's algorithm** builds it with BFS: repeatedly take a node whose **in-degree** (number of incoming edges still unprocessed) is 0. A **union-find** (disjoint-set union) keeps a collection of groups and answers "are x and y in the same group?" and "merge their groups" in almost constant time. **Signal:** "order of tasks with dependencies", "can all courses be finished" → topological sort; "number of connected groups", "does this edge create a cycle", merging accounts or friend circles → union-find. **Cost:** Kahn O(V + E); union-find O(α(n)) per operation, where α (the inverse Ackermann function) is below 5 for any real input.

```
function courseOrder(n, prereqs) {           // prereqs: [course, mustTakeFirst]
  const adj = Array.from({ length: n }, () => []);
  const indeg = new Array(n).fill(0);
  for (const [c, p] of prereqs) { adj[p].push(c); indeg[c]++; }
  const order = [];
  for (let i = 0; i < n; i++) if (indeg[i] === 0) order.push(i);
  for (let h = 0; h < order.length; h++)     // `order` doubles as the queue
    for (const v of adj[order[h]]) if (--indeg[v] === 0) order.push(v);
  return order.length === n ? order : null;  // null = cycle: impossible schedule
}
assert.deepEqual(courseOrder(4, [[1, 0], [2, 0], [3, 1], [3, 2]]), [0, 1, 2, 3]);
assert.equal(courseOrder(2, [[0, 1], [1, 0]]), null);

class UnionFind {
  constructor(n) {
    this.parent = Array.from({ length: n }, (_, i) => i);   // everyone starts alone
    this.size = new Array(n).fill(1);
    this.sets = n;
  }
  find(x) {                                  // follow parents to the group's root
    while (this.parent[x] !== x) {
      this.parent[x] = this.parent[this.parent[x]];        // path halving: flatten as we go
      x = this.parent[x];
    }
    return x;
  }
  union(a, b) {
    let ra = this.find(a), rb = this.find(b);
    if (ra === rb) return false;             // already in the same group
    if (this.size[ra] < this.size[rb]) [ra, rb] = [rb, ra];
    this.parent[rb] = ra;                    // hang the smaller tree under the bigger one
    this.size[ra] += this.size[rb];
    this.sets--;
    return true;
  }
}
const countComponents = (n, edges) => { const uf = new UnionFind(n); for (const [a, b] of edges) uf.union(a, b);
return uf.sets; };
assert.equal(countComponents(5, [[0, 1], [1, 2], [3, 4]]), 2);

function redundantEdge(edges) {              // first edge that closes a cycle (nodes 1..n)
  const uf = new UnionFind(edges.length + 1);
  for (const e of edges) if (!uf.union(e[0], e[1])) return e;
  return null;
}
assert.deepEqual(redundantEdge([[1, 2], [2, 3], [3, 4], [1, 4], [1, 5]]), [1, 4]);
```

Kahn vs the DFS topological sort in Pattern 10: both are O(V + E). Kahn detects a cycle by counting ("fewer than n nodes came out") instead of by recursion colours, needs no recursion (no depth limit), and processes the graph in "waves" — handy when asked for the minimum number of semesters. Union-find answers connectivity for edges that arrive one at a time, where rerunning BFS after each edge would cost O(V + E) each time. The two optimisations (path halving and union by size) are what make it fast; without them a chain of unions can make `find` O(n).

Pattern 18 — Greedy

What it is: a **greedy** algorithm makes the choice that looks best right now and never revisits it. It is fast (usually one pass, often after a sort) but only correct when you can argue that a locally best choice never blocks a globally best answer — so in the interview, always say *why* the greedy choice is safe, or give a counterexample (one input where it gives the wrong answer) and switch to DP (Pattern 11). **Signal:** "minimum number of …", "can you reach …", scheduling, and problems where a sort plus one sweep feels natural. **Cost:** O(n) or O(n log n) with a sort.

```
function canJump(nums) {                    // nums[i] = max jump length from i
  let reach = 0;                            // farthest index reachable so far
  for (let i = 0; i < nums.length; i++) {
    if (i > reach) return false;            // stuck before i
    reach = Math.max(reach, i + nums[i]);
  }
  return true;
}
assert.equal(canJump([3, 2, 1, 0, 4]), false);

function gasStation(gas, cost) {            // start index for a full circle, or -1
  let total = 0, tank = 0, start = 0;
  for (let i = 0; i < gas.length; i++) {
    const d = gas[i] - cost[i];
    total += d; tank += d;
    if (tank < 0) { start = i + 1; tank = 0; }   // nobody in start..i can be the answer
  }
  return total >= 0 ? start : -1;
}
assert.equal(gasStation([1, 2, 3, 4, 5], [3, 4, 5, 1, 2]), 3);

function candies(ratings) {                 // everyone >= 1; higher rating than a neighbour => more
  const n = ratings.length, c = new Array(n).fill(1);
  for (let i = 1; i < n; i++) if (ratings[i] > ratings[i - 1]) c[i] = c[i - 1] + 1;
  for (let i = n - 2; i >= 0; i--) if (ratings[i] > ratings[i + 1]) c[i] = Math.max(c[i], c[i + 1] + 1);
  return c.reduce((a, b) => a + b, 0);
}
assert.equal(candies([1, 3, 4, 5, 2]), 11);  // 1, 2, 3, 4, 1
```

The safety arguments, in one line each. **Jump game:** every index up to `reach` is reachable, so extending `reach` from each of them loses nothing. **Gas station:** if the tank goes negative at `i` after starting at `s`, every station between `s` and `i` arrived with at least 0 fuel from `s`, so starting there is no better — skip to `i + 1`; and if total gas covers total cost, the last surviving start completes the loop. **Candies:** the left-to-right pass satisfies every "better than my left neighbour" rule with the fewest candies, the right-to-left pass does the same for right neighbours, and `Math.max` keeps both. When greedy fails — coin change with coins `[1, 3, 4]` and amount 6 (greedy picks 4+1+1, the best is 3+3) — use DP. (Pattern 6's meeting-rooms and merge-intervals are greedy too: sort, then sweep.)

Pattern 19 — Sort & search: quickselect, Dutch flag, merge sort

Idea: some questions are really about the sorting algorithms themselves: find the k-th item *without* fully sorting, partition in place, or sort stably. **Quickselect** partitions like quicksort (a **pivot** value; smaller items to its left, the rest to its right) but then continues into only the side that contains the answer. **Signal:** "k-th largest/smallest", "median", "sort 0/1/2 in one pass", "sort a linked list", "count inversions" (pairs that are in the wrong order). **Cost:** quickselect O(n) average (O(n²) worst, made unlikely by a random pivot); Dutch flag O(n) one pass, O(1) space; merge sort O(n log n) always, O(n) extra space, **stable**.

```
function kthLargest(nums, k) {                // quickselect
  const a = [...nums], target = a.length - k;   // k-th largest = index n-k ascending
  let lo = 0, hi = a.length - 1;
  for (;;) {
    const r = lo + Math.floor(Math.random() * (hi - lo + 1));
    [a[r], a[hi]] = [a[hi], a[r]];            // random pivot, moved to the end
    const pivot = a[hi];
    let store = lo;                           // Lomuto partition
    for (let i = lo; i < hi; i++) if (a[i] < pivot) { [a[i], a[store]] = [a[store], a[i]]; store++; }
    [a[store], a[hi]] = [a[hi], a[store]];    // the pivot is now in its final sorted place
    if (store === target) return a[store];
    if (store < target) lo = store + 1; else hi = store - 1;   // keep ONE side
  }
}
assert.equal(kthLargest([3, 2, 1, 5, 6, 4], 2), 5);

function sortColors(a) {                      // Dutch national flag: 0s, 1s, 2s in one pass
  let lo = 0, mid = 0, hi = a.length - 1;     // [0,lo)=0s  [lo,mid)=1s  [mid,hi]=unknown  (hi,end]=2s
  while (mid <= hi) {
    if (a[mid] === 0) { [a[lo], a[mid]] = [a[mid], a[lo]]; lo++; mid++; }
    else if (a[mid] === 1) mid++;
    else { [a[mid], a[hi]] = [a[hi], a[mid]]; hi--; }   // don't move mid: new a[mid] is unchecked
  }
  return a;
}
assert.deepEqual(sortColors([2, 0, 2, 1, 1, 0]), [0, 0, 1, 1, 2, 2]);

function mergeSort(a, cmp = (x, y) => x - y) {
  if (a.length <= 1) return a;
  const mid = a.length >> 1;
  const L = mergeSort(a.slice(0, mid), cmp), R = mergeSort(a.slice(mid), cmp);
  const out = [];
  let i = 0, j = 0;
  while (i < L.length && j < R.length) out.push(cmp(L[i], R[j]) <= 0 ? L[i++] : R[j++]);   // <= : stable
  return out.concat(L.slice(i), R.slice(j));
}
const people = [['ann', 30], ['bob', 25], ['cy', 30], ['di', 25]];
assert.deepEqual(mergeSort(people, (x, y) => x[1] - y[1]).map(p => p[0]), ['bob', 'di', 'ann', 'cy']);
```

Quickselect vs a heap (Pattern 7): quickselect is O(n) on average but needs the whole array in memory and rearranges a copy; a size-k heap is O(n log k) but works on a stream. The code file also checks `kthLargest` against `toSorted` on 200 random arrays — a cheap way to test any randomised algorithm. Merge sort's merge step is the same idea as "merge two sorted lists" and, on a linked list, needs no extra array (find the middle with Pattern 14, sort both halves, merge). In everyday JavaScript, `toSorted` is already a stable O(n log n) sort (§17.1); write these only when the question is about the algorithm.

Pattern 20 — Bit manipulation

What it is: treating a number as its binary digits (**bits**) and using the bitwise operators: `&` (and), `|` (or), `^` (xor: 1 when the bits differ), `~` (not), `<<` (shift left = ×2), `>>` (shift right keeping the sign), `>>>` (shift right filling with 0). **Signal:** "without extra space, find the one that appears once", "count 1-bits", "power of two", subsets as bitmasks (an integer whose bits mark which items are chosen). **Cost:** O(1) per operation. **The JavaScript twist:** numbers are 64-bit floats, but every bitwise operator first converts to a **32-bit signed integer**, so results can come out negative and values above

2^{32} lose their high bits; `x >>> 0` reinterprets the 32 bits as unsigned (no sign bit, so never negative).

```
const singleNumber = (nums) => nums.reduce((acc, x) => acc ^ x, 0);   // x ^ x = 0, x ^ 0 = x
assert.equal(singleNumber([4, 1, 2, 1, 2]), 4);

function countBits(n) {                     // number of 1-bits for every i in 0..n
  const bits = new Array(n + 1).fill(0);
  for (let i = 1; i <= n; i++) bits[i] = bits[i >> 1] + (i & 1);   // DP: drop the last bit
  return bits;
}
assert.deepEqual(countBits(5), [0, 1, 1, 2, 1, 2]);

// swap every pair of neighbouring bits: 0xAAAAAAAA = odd positions, 0x55555555 = even
const swapOddEvenBits = (x) => (((x & 0xAAAAAAAA) >>> 1) | ((x & 0x55555555) << 1)) >>> 0;
assert.equal(swapOddEvenBits(0b10110), 0b101001);
assert.equal(swapOddEvenBits(0x40000000), 0x80000000);   // 2147483648, thanks to >>> 0
assert.equal(0x40000000 << 1, -2147483648);              // the trap without it

const isPowerOfTwo = (n) => n > 0 && (n & (n - 1)) === 0;   // n & (n-1) clears the lowest 1-bit
```

`singleNumber` works in any order because xor is commutative and associative (neither the order nor the grouping of the operations changes the result): the pairs cancel and only the lone value is left, with O(1) space instead of a `Set`. `countBits` is a tiny DP: `i >> 1` is `i` without its last bit (already computed) and `i & 1` is that last bit. In the swap, the final `>>> 0` matters: shifting a 1 into bit 31 makes the signed result negative. Because the file asserts against a slow bit-by-bit version on edge values (`0`, `0x80000000`, `0xFFFFFFFF`), the sign bug would be caught. For numbers beyond 32 bits, `BigInt` supports the same operators (`5n & 3n`), except `>>>`.

Pattern 21 — Math & geometry

Idea: simulation and number facts rather than a data structure: walk a matrix in a given order, handle integer limits, compare slopes exactly. The skill is spotting the invariant (a fact that stays true at every step) and the edge cases. **Signal:** "spiral / rotate a matrix", "reverse digits … return 0 on overflow", "points on a line", gcd (greatest common divisor), modular arithmetic (arithmetic with remainders, like hours on a clock). **Cost:** problem-specific — here O(rows × cols), O(digits) and $O(n^2)$.

```
function spiral(m) {                        // peel layers with four shrinking walls
  const out = [];
  let top = 0, bottom = m.length - 1, left = 0, right = m[0].length - 1;
  while (top <= bottom && left <= right) {
    for (let c = left; c <= right; c++) out.push(m[top][c]);
    top++;
    for (let r = top; r <= bottom; r++) out.push(m[r][right]);
    right--;
    if (top <= bottom) { for (let c = right; c >= left; c--) out.push(m[bottom][c]); bottom--; }
    if (left <= right) { for (let r = bottom; r >= top; r--) out.push(m[r][left]); left++; }
  }
  return out;
}
assert.deepEqual(spiral([[1, 2, 3, 4], [5, 6, 7, 8], [9, 10, 11, 12]]), [1, 2, 3, 4, 8, 12, 11, 10, 9, 5, 6, 7]);

function reverseInt(x) {                    // 0 if the result leaves the 32-bit signed range
  const sign = x < 0 ? -1 : 1;
  let n = Math.abs(x), r = 0;
  while (n > 0) { r = r * 10 + (n % 10); n = Math.floor(n / 10); }
  r *= sign;
  return r < -(2 ** 31) || r > 2 ** 31 - 1 ? 0 : r;
}
assert.equal(reverseInt(-120), -21);
assert.equal(reverseInt(1534236469), 0);     // 9646324351 > 2^31 - 1

function maxPointsOnLine(points) {          // most points on one straight line
  if (points.length <= 2) return points.length;
  const gcd = (a, b) => (b === 0 ? Math.abs(a) : gcd(b, a % b));
  let best = 0;
  for (let i = 0; i < points.length; i++) {
    const byDir = new Map();
    let same = 1, most = 0;                  // `same` = the anchor plus exact duplicates
    for (let j = i + 1; j < points.length; j++) {
      let dx = points[j][0] - points[i][0], dy = points[j][1] - points[i][1];
      if (dx === 0 && dy === 0) { same++; continue; }
      const g = gcd(dx, dy);
      dx /= g; dy /= g;
      if (dx < 0 || (dx === 0 && dy < 0)) { dx = -dx; dy = -dy; }   // one sign per direction
      const key = `${dx}/${dy}`;
      const c = (byDir.get(key) ?? 0) + 1;
      byDir.set(key, c);
      most = Math.max(most, c);
    }
    best = Math.max(best, most + same);
  }
  return best;
}
assert.equal(maxPointsOnLine([[1, 1], [3, 2], [5, 3], [4, 1], [2, 3], [1, 4]]), 4);
```

The two `if`s in `spiral` stop a single remaining row or column from being walked twice (try a 3×1 matrix). In `reverseInt`, JavaScript is *easier* than languages with fixed-size integers: numbers are exact up to 2^{53}, so the intermediate value cannot overflow and one range check at the end is enough; in Java or C++ you must check *before* `r * 10`. In `maxPointsOnLine`, a floating-point slope `dy / dx` would be both imprecise (in the code file, `94911150 / 94911151 === 94911151 / 94911152` is `true` although the two directions differ, so three non-collinear points — not on one straight line — would be counted as one line) and infinite for vertical lines; the reduced integer pair as a `Map` key avoids both — the same "canonical key" idea as Pattern 3's anagram grouping.

Output of the graph/greedy/sort/bit/math program:

```
course order 0,1,2,3 | cyclic null | components 2 | redundant [2,3]
canJump true false | gas start 3 | candies 5 11
2nd largest 5 | colors 0,0,1,1,2,2 | mergeSort stable bob,di,ann,cy
single 4 | countBits(5) 0,1,1,2,1,2 | swap bits 22 -> 41 | swap 0x40000000 -> 2147483648
spiral 1,2,3,6,9,8,7,4,5 | reverse -21 0 | max collinear 4
all graph/greedy/sort/bit/math asserts passed
```

Summary table

#	Pattern	Signal words	Time	Extra space
1	Two pointers	sorted, pair, palindrome, in place	O(n)	O(1)
2	Sliding window	longest/shortest contiguous	O(n)	O(k)
3	Hashing	seen before, count, group	O(n)	O(n)
4	Stack / monotonic stack	brackets, next greater	O(n)	O(n)
5	Prefix sums	range sum, subarray sum = k	O(n) + O(1)/query	O(n)
6	Intervals	overlap, merge, rooms	O(n log n)	O(n)
7	Heap (two heaps, k-way merge)	top k, cheapest next, running median	O(n log k)	O(k)
8	Binary search	sorted, minimum value that works	O(log n) × check	O(1)
9	BFS	fewest steps, levels	O(V + E)	O(V)
10	DFS	connected, cycle, order	O(V + E)	O(V)
11	DP + memo	count ways, min cost, overlapping calls	states × transitions	states
12	Backtracking	all combinations, puzzles	exponential	O(depth)
13	Linked lists	reverse, k-th from end, merge, intersection	O(n)	O(1)
14	Fast & slow pointers	cycle, cycle start, middle, "does it loop?"	O(n)	O(1)
15	Trees	validate BST, ancestor, path, serialize	O(n)	O(h)
16	Tries	prefix, autocomplete, wildcard, words in a grid	O(L) per word	O(total chars)
17	Topological sort / union-find	dependencies, order; groups, redundant edge	O(V + E); ≈ O(1) per op	O(V)
18	Greedy	reach, minimum count, schedule (prove the choice)	O(n) or O(n log n)	O(1)–O(n)
19	Sort & search	k-th largest, 3-way partition, stable sort	O(n) avg; O(n log n)	O(1); O(n)
20	Bit manipulation	appears once, count bits, power of two, masks	O(n) or O(1)	O(1)
21	Math & geometry	spiral, overflow, collinear points, gcd	problem-specific	O(1)–O(n)

In the interview

30-second answer — "How do you approach a coding problem?" Restate it; agree on input/output and edge cases (empty, duplicates, negatives). State the brute force (the obvious try-everything solution) and its cost. Find the pattern — sorted → binary search/two pointers; contiguous → window; lookups → hash map; fewest steps → BFS — and state the better complexity before coding. Then test by hand with a normal and an edge case.

- *Why BFS rather than DFS for shortest path?* BFS reaches nodes in order of distance, so the first visit is the shortest; DFS may find a long path first.
- *Top-down or bottom-up DP?* Top-down is easier to derive and computes only needed states; bottom-up avoids recursion-depth limits (important in JavaScript) and allows rolling arrays (keeping only the last row or two of the table).

- *How do you implement a priority queue in JavaScript?* A binary heap over an array: push = append + sift up, pop = move last to root + sift down, both O(log n).
- *Why a dummy head in linked-list problems?* It gives every real node a predecessor, so removing or inserting at the head needs no special case.
- *How do you prove a greedy solution?* Show that the greedy choice can be swapped into any optimal answer without making it worse (an **exchange argument**), or that it keeps an invariant (jump game: everything up to `reach` is reachable). If you can't, try a small counterexample and fall back to DP.
- *Quickselect or heap for the k-th largest?* Quickselect: O(n) average, needs the whole array. Heap of size k: O(n log k), works on a stream and has no bad worst case.
- *Kahn's algorithm or DFS for topological order?* Both O(V + E). Kahn counts nodes to detect a cycle and needs no recursion; DFS uses three colours and post-order.

Self-check

1. Which pattern finds the length of the longest substring with at most two distinct letters? → Sliding window with a `Map` of counts.
2. Why does `subarraySum` start the map with `[0, 1]`? → So subarrays that start at index 0 (prefix sum exactly `k`) are counted.
3. What's wrong with marking BFS cells visited when you dequeue them? → Duplicates enter the queue; still correct but can blow up time and memory.
4. What's the parent index of heap node 6? → `(6 − 1) >> 1 = 2`.
5. In `removeKthFromEnd`, why start both pointers at a dummy node? → So that when k equals the list length, `trail` can stop *before* the head and remove it.
6. Why must `isValidBST` pass a range instead of comparing each node with its parent? → A node can be correct for its parent yet violate an ancestor further up (4 under 7 under 5's right side).
7. What does `union` return in `redundantEdge`, and why does `false` mean a cycle? → `false` = the two ends already had the same root, so a path between them existed and this edge closes a loop.
8. Why does `swapOddEvenBits` end with `>>> 0`? → Bitwise results are 32-bit **signed**; a 1 in bit 31 would print as a negative number. `>>> 0` reads the same bits as unsigned.

TL;DR

Recognise the pattern, state the complexity, then code. Two pointers/window/hashing/prefix sums are O(n) array tricks; stacks handle nesting; sort first for intervals; heaps (hand-written in JS) for top-k, Dijkstra, k-way merge and — two of them — a running median; binary search on data or on the answer; BFS for fewest steps, DFS (iterative for deep inputs) for connectivity; memoize overlapping recursion; backtrack with choose/explore/un-choose and copy results. Linked lists: rewire with a dummy head; fast & slow pointers find cycles and middles in O(1) space; trees: recursion that combines subtree answers (pass ranges down for BSTs); tries for prefixes; Kahn's algorithm for dependency order, union-find for growing groups; greedy only with a safety argument; quickselect for the k-th item, Dutch flag for 3-way partitions, merge sort when stability matters; bitwise ops are 32-bit signed (`>>> 0` for unsigned); in math problems use exact integer keys, not float slopes.

17.3 Implement-from-scratch classics

What it is

"Implement `X` without using the built-in" questions test whether you understand *how* everyday tools work: closures and timers (`debounce`, `throttle`), `this` and `apply` (`bind`), recursion and object types (deep clone, deep equal), `Map` ordering (LRU cache), and promises (`Promise.all`). Each implementation below is short, correct for the cases interviewers probe, and tested.

How the tests control time

`debounce` and `throttle` depend on time, and real timers make tests slow and flaky. `code/04_classics_functions.mjs` uses the **fake timers** from `node:test` (§16.5): `setTimeout` and `Date.now()` only move forward when the test calls `tick(ms)`.

```
import { mock } from 'node:test';
mock.timers.enable({ apis: ['setTimeout', 'Date'] });
const tick = (ms) => mock.timers.tick(ms);
```

Debounce

What it is: a **debounced** function waits until calls *stop* for `wait` ms, then runs once with the latest arguments. Analogy: a lift door that stays open while people keep walking in, and closes only after nobody has come for a few seconds. **Use it for:** search-as-you-type, auto-save, resize handling.

```
function debounce(fn, wait) {
  let timer = null;
  function debounced(...args) {
    clearTimeout(timer);                          // every call restarts the countdown
    timer = setTimeout(() => { timer = null; fn.apply(this, args); }, wait);
  }
  debounced.cancel = () => { clearTimeout(timer); timer = null; };
  return debounced;
}

const calls = [];
const search = debounce((q) => calls.push(q), 300);
search('j'); tick(100); search('ja'); tick(100); search('jav'); // user still typing
tick(299); assert.deepEqual(calls, []);            // 299 ms after the last key: nothing yet
tick(1);   assert.deepEqual(calls, ['jav']);       // fires once, with the LAST args
search('x'); search.cancel(); tick(1000);
assert.deepEqual(calls, ['jav']);                  // cancelled
```

Output: `debounce calls: [ 'jav' ]`

Interviewers check: (1) the timer lives in a **closure** shared by all calls; (2) `debounced` is a regular `function` forwarding `this` and arguments with `apply`, so it works as a method; (3) a `cancel` method (Lodash — a popular utility library — also offers `flush` and `leading`).

Throttle

What it is: a **throttled** function runs **at most once per** `wait` **ms**, however often it's called. Analogy: a bus that leaves every 10 minutes whether 1 or 50 people arrive. **Use it for:** scroll and mousemove handlers, rate-limited API calls (APIs that allow only so many calls per second). This version runs on

the **leading** edge (immediately) and also on the **trailing** edge (once more at the end with the latest arguments) so the final position is never lost.

```
function throttle(fn, wait) {
  let last = -Infinity, timer = null, pendingArgs = null, pendingThis = null;
  function throttled(...args) {
    const now = Date.now(), remaining = wait - (now - last);
    if (remaining <= 0) {                          // window open: run now (leading edge)
      clearTimeout(timer); timer = null;
      last = now; fn.apply(this, args);
    } else {                                       // inside window: remember the latest call
      pendingArgs = args; pendingThis = this;
      timer ??= setTimeout(() => {                 // trailing edge
        last = Date.now(); timer = null;
        fn.apply(pendingThis, pendingArgs);
      }, remaining);
    }
  }
  return throttled;
}

const calls = [], t0 = Date.now();
const onScroll = throttle((y) => calls.push(`${y}@${Date.now() - t0}`), 100);
for (let t = 0; t <= 250; t += 10) { onScroll(t); tick(10); }  // an event every 10 ms
for (let i = 0; i < 20; i++) tick(10);                          // then 200 quiet ms
assert.deepEqual(calls, ['0@0', '90@100', '190@200', '250@300']);
```

Output: `throttle calls: [ '0@0', '90@100', '190@200', '250@300' ]` — 26 events became 4 calls, exactly 100 ms apart, and the last one carries the final value `250`.

	Debounce	Throttle
Runs	Once, after the calls stop	Regularly, at most once per interval
During a long burst	Never (until it ends)	Every `wait` ms
Typical use	Search box, auto-save, validation	Scroll, drag, resize-driven layout, analytics

In the browser, visual updates tied to scrolling are often better done with `requestAnimationFrame` (once per frame) — see §14.5.

Curry

What it is: **currying** turns `f(a, b, c)` into a chain `f(a)(b)(c)`. The usual interview version also accepts several arguments at once. It relies on `fn.length` — the number of declared parameters (it doesn't count default or rest parameters).

```
function curry(fn) {
  return function curried(...args) {
    if (args.length >= fn.length) return fn.apply(this, args);     // enough: call it
    return (...more) => curried.apply(this, [...args, ...more]);   // else collect more
  };
}
const add3 = curry((a, b, c) => a + b + c);
assert.equal(add3(1)(2)(3), 6);
assert.equal(add3(1, 2)(3), 6);
const add1 = add3(1);                                  // partials are reusable
assert.equal(add1(10)(20), 31); assert.equal(add1(0)(0), 1);

// Variant: unknown number of arguments, ended by an empty call
const sum = (a) => (b) => (b === undefined ? a : sum(a + b));
assert.equal(sum(1)(2)(3)(), 6);
```

Reusability works because each call builds a **new** argument array instead of pushing into a shared one — a common bug.

Compose and pipe

Function composition chains functions so the output of one is the input of the next. `compose(f, g)(x)` = `f(g(x))` (right to left, as in maths); `pipe(f, g)(x)` = `g(f(x))` (left to right, as you read).

```
const compose = (...fns) => (x) => fns.reduceRight((acc, f) => f(acc), x);
const pipe = (...fns) => (x) => fns.reduce((acc, f) => f(acc), x);
const inc = (x) => x + 1, dbl = (x) => x * 2;
assert.equal(compose(inc, dbl)(5), 11);               // inc(dbl(5))
assert.equal(pipe(inc, dbl)(5), 12);                  // dbl(inc(5))
assert.equal(pipe()(7), 7);                           // no functions = identity
```

Memoize

Memoization caches a pure function's results by its arguments. Key design questions: how to build the key (here `JSON.stringify(args)`, overridable), and where the cache lives (a `Map`, which can grow forever — production code bounds it, e.g. with the LRU cache below).

```
function memoize(fn, keyOf = (...args) => JSON.stringify(args)) {
  const cache = new Map();
  return function (...args) {
    const key = keyOf(...args);
    if (cache.has(key)) return cache.get(key);        // has(): a cached undefined still counts
    const value = fn.apply(this, args);
    cache.set(key, value);
    return value;
  };
}
let runs = 0;
const slowSquare = memoize((n) => { runs++; return n * n; });
slowSquare(4); slowSquare(4); slowSquare(5);
assert.equal(runs, 2);
// Recursive functions must call the MEMOIZED version, or only the top call is cached
const fib = memoize((n) => (n < 2 ? n : fib(n - 1) + fib(n - 2)));
```

Output: `memoize runs: 2 | fib(50): 12586269025`. `JSON.stringify` keys can't tell apart some values (`undefined` and `null` in arrays both become `null`; objects with different key orders differ) — mention it and offer a custom `keyOf`, or a `WeakMap` (a `Map` whose object keys don't stop garbage collection) for single-object arguments.

Flatten

Flatten a nested array to a given depth, exactly like the built-in `arr.flat(depth)` (§7.5):

```
function flatten(arr, depth = Infinity) {
  const out = [];
  for (const x of arr) {
    if (Array.isArray(x) && depth > 0) out.push(...flatten(x, depth - 1));
    else out.push(x);
  }
  return out;
}
function flattenDeep(arr) {                    // iterative: no recursion limit
  const stack = [...arr], out = [];
  while (stack.length) {
    const x = stack.pop();
    if (Array.isArray(x)) stack.push(...x); else out.push(x);
  }
  return out.reverse();                        // we took items from the end
}
const nested = [1, [2, [3, [4]], 5]];
assert.deepEqual(flatten(nested, 1), nested.flat(1));   // [1, 2, [3, [4]], 5]
assert.deepEqual(flattenDeep(nested), nested.flat(Infinity));

function flattenObject(obj, prefix = '', out = {}) {     // frequent variant: dotted keys
  for (const [k, v] of Object.entries(obj)) {
    const key = prefix ? `${prefix}.${k}` : k;
    if (v && typeof v === 'object' && !Array.isArray(v)) flattenObject(v, key, out);
    else out[key] = v;
  }
  return out;
}
assert.deepEqual(flattenObject({ a: 1, b: { c: 2, d: { e: 3 } } }), { a: 1, 'b.c': 2, 'b.d.e': 3 });
```

A `bind` polyfill (and `call`)

A **polyfill** is code that implements a standard feature for environments that lack it (§10.12). `bind` must (1) fix `this`, (2) pre-fill arguments (partial application), and (3) when the bound function is used with `new`, ignore the bound `this` and construct normally. How `this` works is in §9.1–9.2.

```
Function.prototype.myBind = function (thisArg, ...preset) {
  const target = this;                                  // the function myBind was called on
  if (typeof target !== 'function') throw new TypeError('myBind must be called on a function');
  function bound(...later) {
    if (new.target) return new target(...preset, ...later);   // called with `new`
    return target.apply(thisArg, [...preset, ...later]);
  }
  return bound;
};
const user = { name: 'Ada' };
function greet(greeting, punct) { return `${greeting}, ${this.name}${punct}`; }
const hi = greet.myBind(user, 'Hi');
assert.equal(hi('!'), 'Hi, Ada!');
assert.equal(hi.call({ name: 'Bob' }, '?'), 'Hi, Ada?');   // bound this can't be overridden
function Point(x, y) { this.x = x; this.y = y; }
const p = new (Point.myBind(null, 1))(2);
assert.ok(p instanceof Point);                                // { x: 1, y: 2 }

Function.prototype.myCall = function (thisArg, ...args) {
  const ctx = thisArg == null ? globalThis : Object(thisArg);   // sloppy-mode rule
  const key = Symbol('fn');                                     // unique: can't clash
  ctx[key] = this;                                              // call it AS A METHOD of ctx
  try { return ctx[key](...args); } finally { delete ctx[key]; }
};
```

Output: `myBind: Hi, Ada! | new bound -> {"x":1,"y":2}`

`myCall` shows the classic trick: calling a function as a method of `ctx` makes `this === ctx`. (The real `call` doesn't box primitives — wrap them in object form, like `Object(5)` — or default to `globalThis` in strict code — that's the sloppy-mode behaviour.) Adding methods to built-in prototypes is fine in an interview but **not** in real code — it can clash with future standard methods.

Deep clone: `structuredClone` vs manual

A **shallow copy** (`{ ...obj }`, `[...arr]`, `Object.assign`) copies the top level only; nested objects are still shared. A **deep copy** copies every level. The built-in is `structuredClone` (browsers since 2022, Node 17+), which uses the *structured clone algorithm* (the one `postMessage` uses).

From `code/05_classics_data.mjs`:

```
const original = {
  when: new Date(0), tags: new Set(['a']), meta: new Map([['k', { n: 1 }]]),
  nested: { list: [1, { deep: true }] },
};
original.self = original;                                  // a cycle
const copy = structuredClone(original);                    // Date, Set, Map, cycles: all fine
structuredClone({ f() {} });                               // throws DataCloneError
structuredClone(new Point(-3));                            // becomes a plain { x: -3 }
JSON.parse(JSON.stringify({ d: new Date(0), u: undefined, m: new Map([[1, 2]]), n: NaN }));
```

Output:

```
structuredClone keeps Date/Set/Map/cycles: 1970-01-01T00:00:00.000Z [ 'a' ] true
function -> DataCloneError
class instance -> plain object: false {"x":-3}
JSON clone: { d: '1970-01-01T00:00:00.000Z', m: {}, n: null }
```

	Spread / `Object.assign`	`JSON.parse(JSON.stringify(x))`	`structuredClone(x)`	Manual `deepClone`
Depth	Top level only	Deep	Deep	Deep
`Date`	Shared	Becomes a string	✓	✓
`Map` / `Set`	Shared	Become `{}`	✓	✓
`undefined`, `NaN`, `Infinity`	✓	Dropped / `null`	✓	✓
Cycles	✓ (shared)	Throws `TypeError`	✓	✓ (with a `WeakMap`)
Functions	Shared	Dropped	Throws `DataCloneError`	Shared (as written)
Class prototype	Lost (spread gives a plain object)	Lost	Lost	Kept (as written)
Getters, property descriptors (a property's hidden settings: writable, enumerable, getter/setter)	Values copied	Values copied	Values copied	Values copied

The manual version interviewers ask for — a recursive walk that handles primitives, `Date`, `RegExp`, `Map`, `Set`, arrays, objects with their prototype, and **cycles** via a `WeakMap` of already-copied objects:

```
function deepClone(value, seen = new WeakMap()) {
  if (value === null || typeof value !== 'object') return value;   // primitives & functions
  if (seen.has(value)) return seen.get(value);                     // cycles / shared refs
  if (value instanceof Date) return new Date(value);
  if (value instanceof RegExp) return new RegExp(value.source, value.flags);
  if (value instanceof Map) {
    const m = new Map(); seen.set(value, m);                       // register BEFORE recursing
    for (const [k, v] of value) m.set(deepClone(k, seen), deepClone(v, seen));
    return m;
  }
  if (value instanceof Set) {
    const s = new Set(); seen.set(value, s);
    for (const v of value) s.add(deepClone(v, seen));
    return s;
  }
  const out = Array.isArray(value) ? [] : Object.create(Object.getPrototypeOf(value));
  seen.set(value, out);
  for (const key of Reflect.ownKeys(value)) {                      // strings AND symbols
    const desc = Object.getOwnPropertyDescriptor(value, key);
    if (desc.enumerable) out[key] = deepClone(value[key], seen);
  }
  return out;
}
```

Output: `deepClone keeps class: true | shared ref kept: true` — the copy of `new Point(-3)` still has `norm()`, and an object referenced twice in the original is one object (referenced twice) in the copy.

Which to use? `structuredClone` for data; a manual clone only to keep class instances — where a `clone()` method is usually clearer.

Deep equal

Compare two values structurally. Decisions to state out loud: `NaN` equals `NaN`? (yes, via `Object.is`); `0` vs `-0`? (not equal with `Object.is` — say which you want); do prototypes have to match? (yes, so `[1, 2]` ≠ `{0: 1, 1: 2}`); does `{a: 1}` equal `{a: 1, b: undefined}`? (no — the key sets differ).

```
function deepEqual(a, b, seen = new WeakMap()) {
  if (Object.is(a, b)) return true;                          // handles NaN and -0 vs +0
  if (typeof a !== 'object' || typeof b !== 'object' || a === null || b === null) return false;
  if (Object.getPrototypeOf(a) !== Object.getPrototypeOf(b)) return false;
  if (seen.get(a) === b) return true;                        // already comparing this pair (cycles)
  seen.set(a, b);
  if (a instanceof Date) return a.getTime() === b.getTime();
  if (a instanceof RegExp) return String(a) === String(b);
  if (a instanceof Map) {
    if (a.size !== b.size) return false;
    for (const [k, v] of a) if (!b.has(k) || !deepEqual(v, b.get(k), seen)) return false;
    return true;
  }
  if (a instanceof Set) {
    if (a.size !== b.size) return false;
    for (const v of a) if (!b.has(v)) return false;          // primitive members only (simplification)
    return true;
  }
  const ka = Reflect.ownKeys(a), kb = Reflect.ownKeys(b);
  if (ka.length !== kb.length) return false;
  return ka.every((k) => Object.hasOwn(b, k) && deepEqual(a[k], b[k], seen));
}
assert.ok(deepEqual({ a: [1, { b: NaN }] }, { a: [1, { b: NaN }] }));
assert.ok(!deepEqual({ a: 1 }, { a: 1, b: undefined }));
assert.ok(!deepEqual([1, 2], { 0: 1, 1: 2 }));
{ const x = { v: 1 }; x.me = x; const y = { v: 1 }; y.me = y; assert.ok(deepEqual(x, y)); }
```

In tests you don't write this: `assert.deepStrictEqual` does it (§16.2).

LRU cache

An **LRU (least recently used) cache** holds at most `capacity` entries; when full, it evicts the entry that was used longest ago. The textbook design is a hash map plus a doubly linked list (each node links to both the previous and the next one). Caches in general — keeping copies of results so repeat requests are fast — are covered in System Design Fundamentals. In JavaScript a single `Map` is enough, because a `Map` iterates in insertion order: delete-and-reinsert moves a key to the "newest" end, and `map.keys().next().value` is the oldest. Both operations are O(1).

```
class LRUCache {
  #cap; #map = new Map();
  constructor(capacity) { this.#cap = capacity; }
  get(key) {
    if (!this.#map.has(key)) return -1;
    const v = this.#map.get(key);
    this.#map.delete(key); this.#map.set(key, v);           // move to "most recent" end
    return v;
  }
  put(key, value) {
    this.#map.delete(key);                                   // updating also refreshes recency
    this.#map.set(key, value);
    if (this.#map.size > this.#cap) {
      const oldest = this.#map.keys().next().value;          // first key = least recent
      this.#map.delete(oldest);
    }
  }
  keys() { return [...this.#map.keys()]; }
}
const lru = new LRUCache(2);
lru.put('a', 1); lru.put('b', 2);
assert.equal(lru.get('a'), 1);          // a is now most recent
lru.put('c', 3);                        // evicts b
assert.equal(lru.get('b'), -1);
lru.put('a', 10);                       // update moves a to the end
assert.deepEqual(lru.keys(), ['c', 'a']);
```

If the interviewer forbids the `Map` trick, build the linked list: nodes with `prev`/`next`, a `Map` from key to node, and dummy head/tail nodes so insert and remove never special-case the ends. The LLD (low-level design) handbook builds the linked-list version (in Java) with eviction policies (rules for what to throw out) and thread safety (staying correct when several threads use it at once): §20.3.

EventEmitter

The **publish/subscribe** pattern: code registers listeners for named events; `emit` calls them in registration order. Node's own `EventEmitter` is covered in §15.8; this is the interview version with `on`, `off`, `once` and `emit`.

```
class EventEmitter {
  #listeners = new Map();                                  // event -> array of fns
  on(event, fn) {
    if (!this.#listeners.has(event)) this.#listeners.set(event, []);
    this.#listeners.get(event).push(fn);
    return () => this.off(event, fn);                      // handy unsubscribe
  }
  off(event, fn) {
    const list = this.#listeners.get(event);
    if (!list) return this;
    const i = list.findIndex((l) => l === fn || l.original === fn);
    if (i !== -1) list.splice(i, 1);
    return this;
  }
  once(event, fn) {
    const wrapper = (...args) => { this.off(event, wrapper); fn.apply(this, args); };
    wrapper.original = fn;                                 // so off(event, fn) still works
    return this.on(event, wrapper);
  }
  emit(event, ...args) {
    const list = this.#listeners.get(event);
    if (!list || list.length === 0) {
      if (event === 'error') throw args[0];                // same rule as Node
      return false;
    }
    for (const fn of [...list]) fn.apply(this, args);      // copy: listeners may unsubscribe
    return true;
  }
  listenerCount(event) { return this.#listeners.get(event)?.length ?? 0; }
}
```

Output: `EventEmitter log: [ 'A:1', 'once:1', 'B:1', 'B:2' ]`

A good answer iterates over a **copy** of the listener list (a `once` listener removes itself during `emit`, which would otherwise skip the next one), lets `off` remove a `once` listener by the original function, throws on an unhandled `'error'` like Node, and returns an unsubscribe function.

`Promise.all`, `allSettled`, `race`, `any` polyfills

How the real combinators behave is in §12.8. From `code/06_promise_polyfills.mjs`:

```
function promiseAll(iterable) {
  return new Promise((resolve, reject) => {
    const items = [...iterable];                        // accept any iterable
    const results = new Array(items.length);
    let remaining = items.length;
    if (remaining === 0) return resolve(results);       // all([]) resolves immediately
    items.forEach((item, i) => {
      Promise.resolve(item).then((v) => {               // wrap non-promises too
        results[i] = v;                                 // by index, not push -> keeps order
        if (--remaining === 0) resolve(results);
      }, reject);                                       // first rejection wins; later ones ignored
    });
  });
}

function promiseAllSettled(iterable) {                  // never rejects
  return promiseAll([...iterable].map((item) =>
    Promise.resolve(item).then(
      (value) => ({ status: 'fulfilled', value }),
      (reason) => ({ status: 'rejected', reason }))));
}

function promiseRace(iterable) {                        // first to SETTLE, either way
  return new Promise((resolve, reject) => {
    for (const item of iterable) Promise.resolve(item).then(resolve, reject);
  });                                                   // race([]) stays pending forever
}

function promiseAny(iterable) {                         // first to FULFIL
  return new Promise((resolve, reject) => {
    const items = [...iterable], errors = new Array(items.length);
    let remaining = items.length;
    if (remaining === 0) return reject(new AggregateError([], 'All promises were rejected'));
    items.forEach((item, i) => Promise.resolve(item).then(resolve, (e) => {
      errors[i] = e;
      if (--remaining === 0) reject(new AggregateError(errors, 'All promises were rejected'));
    }));
  });
}
```

The tests run each polyfill next to the built-in:

```
const all = await promiseAll([sleep(30, 'slow'), sleep(25, 'fast'), 42]);
assert.deepEqual(all, ['slow', 'fast', 42]);            // input order, not finish order
assert.deepEqual(await promiseAll([]), []);
await assert.rejects(promiseAll([sleep(20, 'ok'), sleep(5, 'bad', true)]), /bad/);
assert.equal(await promiseRace([sleep(20, 'a'), sleep(5, 'b')]), 'b');
assert.equal(await promiseAny([sleep(5, 'e1', true), sleep(15, 'win')]), 'win');
```

Output:

```
all: [ 'slow', 'fast', 42 ] | parallel (under 55 ms)? true
allSettled: [ 1, 'rejected(x)', 'y' ]
race: b
any all-rejected: AggregateError [ 'p', 'q' ]
pool results: [ 't0', 't1', 't2', 't3', 't4' ] peak concurrency: 2
all promise asserts passed
```

Four things interviewers look for in `Promise.all`: results **by index** (not `push`, which orders by finish time); a **counter**, not `results.length` (a pre-sized array's length is already full); `Promise.resolve(item)` so plain values work; and an **empty input** that resolves immediately. A settled promise ignores later calls, so `reject` can be passed straight through.

The same file also builds on these: a **timeout** (`race` a promise against a rejecting timer), **`promisify`** (wrap an error-first callback API — Node ships `util.promisify`), a **concurrency-limited pool** (run at most *n* tasks at once, results in order — the peak is asserted to be 2), and **retry**. The pool core:

```
async function pool(tasks, limit) {
  const results = new Array(tasks.length);
  let next = 0;
  async function worker() {
    while (next < tasks.length) {
      const i = next++;                    // no race: nothing else runs between these lines
      results[i] = await tasks[i]();
    }
  }
  await Promise.all(Array.from({ length: Math.min(limit, tasks.length) }, worker));
  return results;
}
```

More production-ready patterns (retry with back-off, stale responses) are in §12.13.

Common mistakes

- Using arrow functions for `debounced`/`throttled`/`memoized` wrappers, which silently drops the caller's `this`.
- `Promise.all` with `results.push(v)` (wrong order) or `if (results.length === n)` (fires too early).
- Deep clone without a `seen` map — infinite recursion on the first cycle.
- `curry` that mutates a shared argument array, so partial functions interfere with each other.
- `EventEmitter.emit` iterating the live array while a `once` listener removes itself.

In the interview

30-second answer — "Implement debounce." Return a wrapper holding a timer in a closure; each call clears it and starts a new `wait`-ms timer; when it fires, call the original with the latest arguments and `this`. Add `cancel`; mention the leading-edge option.

- *Debounce vs throttle?* Debounce waits for quiet and runs once; throttle runs at a steady maximum rate during activity.
- *Why store `Promise.all` results by index?* Promises finish in any order; the result must match the input order.
- *Why is a `Map` enough for an LRU cache?* It preserves insertion order and supports O(1) delete/insert, so "move to newest" = delete + set and "oldest" = first key.

Self-check

1. What does `debounce` do with the arguments of calls that were superseded? → Nothing — only the last call's arguments are used.
2. What does `Promise.race([])` return? → A promise that never settles.
3. Why does `deepClone` call `seen.set` *before* copying children? → So a child that points back to the parent finds the copy instead of recursing forever.
4. What is `fn.length` for `(a, b = 2, ...rest) => {}`? → `1` — counting stops at the first default or rest parameter.

TL;DR

Closures hold state (`debounce` timer, `memoize` cache, `curry` arguments); forward `this` with `apply`; `bind` must handle `new`. `structuredClone` for data, manual clone for class instances, `WeakMap` for cycles. LRU = one `Map`. EventEmitter: copy the list before emitting. `Promise.all`: index, counter, `Promise.resolve`, empty input.

17.4 Fifty-three tricky interview questions

How to use this section

Each question shows the code, the **real output** (from `code/07_qa_language.js` — CommonJS in sloppy mode on purpose, so legacy behaviour is visible — and `code/08_qa_async_and_memory.mjs`), a short answer you can say out loud, and a link to the section that teaches the topic properly. Cover the answer, predict the output, then check.

17.4.1 Coercion and equality

Q1. What do `1 + '2'`, `'5' - 2`, `'3' * '4'`, `true + 1`, `[] + []`, `[] + {}` and `[1,2] + [3]` give?

```
Q1  1 + '2'                    "12"
Q1  '5' - 2                    3
Q1  '3' * '4'                  12
Q1  true + 1                   2
Q1  [] + []                    ""
Q1  [] + {}                    "[object Object]"
Q1  [1,2] + [3]                "1,23"
```

`+` first turns objects into primitives (arrays → `"1,2"`-style strings, plain objects → `"[object Object]"`); if **either** side is then a string it concatenates, otherwise it adds. `-`, `*`, `/` always convert to numbers. (At the start of a console line, `{} + []` is `0`: `{}` parses as an empty block and `+[]` is unary plus — the `+x` operator that converts `x` to a number.) → §2.5, §2.12

Q2. What do `null == undefined`, `null == 0`, `null >= 0`, `'' == 0` and `'0' == false` give?

```
Q2  null == undefined          true
Q2  null == 0                  false
Q2  null >= 0                  true
Q2  '' == 0                    true
Q2  '0' == false               true
```

`==` converts types first (booleans and strings become numbers), but `null` and `undefined` are `==` only to each other, so `null == 0` is false. Relational operators (`<`, `>`, `<=`, `>=`) have no such exception — `null` becomes `0`, so `null >= 0` is true. Use `===`; keep `x == null` for a deliberate "null or undefined" check. → §2.6

Q3. Why is `[] == ![]` true?

```
Q3  [] == ![]                  true
```

`![]` is `false` (every object is truthy). Now `[] == false`: the boolean becomes `0`, the array becomes `''` then `0`, and `0 == 0`. The same array is "equal to its own negation" — the best argument for `===`. → §2.6, §2.11

Q4. What is `typeof null`, and why?

```
Q4  typeof null                "object"
```

A bug from the first engine (1995): values carried a type tag, objects had tag 0, and `null` (the null pointer — a reference to nothing, stored as 0) also read as tag 0. Fixing it would break the web. Use `x === null`, and `x !== null && typeof x === 'object'` for "a real object". → §2.3

Q5. How does `NaN` behave?

```
Q5  NaN === NaN                false
Q5  [NaN].includes(NaN)        true
Q5  [NaN].indexOf(NaN)         -1
Q5  typeof NaN                 "number"
```

`NaN` (the result of failed numeric operations like `0 / 0`) is the only value not equal to itself. `indexOf` uses `===`, so it can't find it; `includes`, `Map` and `Set` use SameValueZero, where `NaN` equals

`NaN`. Test with `Number.isNaN`, not the global `isNaN`, which converts first (`isNaN('x')` is `true`). → §2.10

Q6. How does `Object.is` differ from `===`?

```
Q6  Object.is(-0, 0) / -0 === 0    "false / true"
```

Only in two cases: `Object.is(NaN, NaN)` is `true` and `Object.is(0, -0)` is `false`. React uses `Object.is` to decide whether state changed. → §2.6

Q7. What does `typeof` return for arrays, functions, classes and undeclared variables?

```
Q7  typeof [] / function / class   "object / function / function"
Q7  typeof undeclaredVar           "undefined"
```

Arrays are objects — use `Array.isArray`. Classes are functions underneath. `typeof` on a name that was never declared returns `'undefined'` instead of throwing (useful for feature detection — checking whether an API exists before using it) — but see Q16 for the TDZ exception. → §2.3

Q8. Which values are falsy? Is `[]` truthy? And `new Boolean(false)`?

```
Q8  Boolean([]), Boolean('0')      "true, true"
Q8  !!new Boolean(false)           true
```

Falsy: `false`, `0`, `-0`, `0n`, `''`, `null`, `undefined`, `NaN` (plus the legacy `document.all`). Everything else is truthy — `[]`, `{}`, `'0'`, `'false'`, even a `Boolean` object holding `false`. Test an empty array with `arr.length === 0`. → §2.11

Q9. What does `'b' + 'a' + +'a' + 'a'` give?

```
Q9  'b' + 'a' + +'a' + 'a'         "baNaNa"
```

`+'a'` is unary plus: it converts `'a'` to a number, which is `NaN`; concatenation turns it into the text `"NaN"`. → §2.5

Q10. Why does `['1', '7', '11'].map(parseInt)` give `[1, NaN, 3]`?

```
Q10 ['1','7','11'].map(parseInt)   [ 1, NaN, 3 ]
Q10 ['1','7','11'].map(Number)     [ 1, 7, 11 ]
```

`map` passes `(value, index, array)`, and `parseInt`'s second parameter is the **radix** (the number base, e.g. 10 for decimal, 2 for binary): `parseInt('1', 0)` (0 = default base 10 → 1), `parseInt('7', 1)` (invalid base → `NaN`), `parseInt('11', 2)` (binary → 3). Fix: `map(Number)` or `map((s) => parseInt(s, 10))`. → §7.5, §2.10

Q11. Why does `[10, 1, 2].sort()` give `[1, 10, 2]`?

```
Q11 [10, 1, 2].sort()              [ 1, 10, 2 ]
```

Without a comparator, `sort` compares elements as strings, and `'10' < '2'` because `'1' < '2'`. Pass `(a, b) => a - b`. → §7.6

Q12. What's the difference between `||` and `??`?

```
Q12 0 || 'x' / 0 ?? 'x'            "x / 0"
```

`a || b` falls back to `b` when `a` is **any falsy** value, so it wrongly replaces a legitimate `0`, `''` or `false`. `a ?? b` (nullish coalescing, ES2020) falls back only when `a` is `null` or `undefined`. Use `??` for defaults. → §2.7

Q13. Why is `{} === {}` false?

```
Q13 {} === {}                      false
```

Objects (including arrays and functions) are compared by **reference** — "is this the same object in memory?" — not by content. Two literals create two objects. To compare content, use a deep-equal (§17.3). → §2.4

Q14. Why is `0.1 + 0.2 !== 0.3`? And why is `Math.max() < Math.min()`?

```
Q14 0.1 + 0.2 === 0.3              false
Q14 Math.max() < Math.min()        true
```

0.1 and 0.2 have no exact binary (IEEE 754) form, so the sum is `0.30000000000000004` — compare with a tolerance or use integers (§17.1). With no arguments `Math.max()` is `-Infinity` (the identity for "max") and `Math.min()` is `Infinity`. → §2.10

17.4.2 Scope, hoisting and closures

Q15. What are the differences between `var`, `let` and `const`?

	var	let	const
Scope	Function	Block `{ }`	Block `{ }`
Before the declaration line	`undefined` (hoisted and initialised)	`ReferenceError` (TDZ)	`ReferenceError` (TDZ)
Redeclare in the same scope	Allowed	`SyntaxError`	`SyntaxError`
Reassign	Yes	Yes	No (`TypeError`)
At top level of a script	Becomes a property of `globalThis`	Doesn't	Doesn't

`const` stops *reassignment* of the variable, not mutation of the object it points to (Q44). Default to `const`, use `let` when you must reassign, avoid `var`. → §2.1

Q16. What happens when you read a variable before its declaration?

```
Q16 var read before declaration    "undefined"
Q16 let read before declaration    "ReferenceError: Cannot access 'tdz' before initialization"
Q16 typeof in the TDZ              "ReferenceError: Cannot access 'inTdz' before initialization"
```

All declarations are **hoisted** (registered on entering the scope); `var` is also initialised to `undefined`. `let`, `const` and `class` stay uninitialised until their line runs — the **temporal dead zone (TDZ)** — and any access throws, even `typeof`. → §2.2

Q17. Can you call a function before it's defined?

```
Q17 declaration hoisted            "works"
Q17 expression not hoisted         "TypeError: late is not a function"
```

A function **declaration** is hoisted with its body. A function **expression** in a `var` hoists only the variable (`undefined`), so calling it throws `TypeError`; with `let`/`const` it's a TDZ `ReferenceError`. → §4.2

Q18. What do these loops print?

```
for (var i = 0; i < 3; i++) setTimeout(() => out.var.push(i), 0);
for (let j = 0; j < 3; j++) setTimeout(() => out.let.push(j), 0);
for (var k = 0; k < 3; k++) ((k2) => setTimeout(() => out.fixed.push(k2), 0))(k);
```

```
Q18 closures in loops              {"var":[3,3,3],"let":[0,1,2],"fixed":[0,1,2]}
```

The callbacks run after the loop. `var` has **one** `i` for the whole function — `3` by then. `let` in a `for` header creates a **fresh binding per iteration**. The pre-ES2015 fix was an IIFE (immediately invoked function expression — a function defined and called on the spot) copying the value into a parameter. → §4.7

Q19. What is a closure? Show one.

```
const makeCounter = () => { let n = 0; return () => ++n; };
const c1 = makeCounter(), c2 = makeCounter();
c1(); c1();
```

```
Q19 counter via closure            "c1: 3, c2: 1"
```

A **closure** is a function plus the variables of the scope where it was created, kept alive and updatable after the outer function returns. Each `makeCounter()` call creates a new `n`, so `c1` and `c2` are independent. Uses: private state, factories, `debounce`/`memoize` (§17.3). → §4.7

Q20. What's wrong with `let a = b = 5`?

```
(function () { let a = b = 5; })();
```

```
Q20 let a = b = 5                  "outside: typeof a=undefined, typeof b=number"
```

It parses as `b = 5; let a = b;`. `a` is local, but `b` was never declared, so in sloppy mode the assignment creates an **accidental global**. In strict mode it throws `ReferenceError` (Q22). → §4.5

Q21. Is a `var` inside an `if` block visible outside it?

```
Q21 var in block leaks             "v=1, typeof l=undefined"
```

Yes: `var` ignores blocks and belongs to the whole function. `let`/`const` are confined to the block. → §4.5

Q22. What does strict mode change?

```
Q22/Q23 strict: lost this      TypeError: Cannot read properties of undefined (reading 'name')
Q22 strict: undeclared assign  ReferenceError: undeclaredThing is not defined
```

Strict mode (automatic in ES modules and class bodies) turns silent mistakes into errors: undeclared assignments and writes to read-only properties throw, `this` in a plain call is `undefined` instead of `globalThis`, and duplicate parameter names and `with` are syntax errors. → §1.8

17.4.3 `this`, arrow functions, `call`/`apply`/`bind`, `new`

Q23. Why does a method lose `this` when you pass it around?

```
const f = user.regular; f();
```

```
Q23 method call                    "Ada"
Q23 extracted method (sloppy)      undefined
```

`this` is decided by **how** a function is called. `user.regular()` sets `this = user`; a plain `f()` gives `undefined` in strict code (→ `TypeError`, Q22) or `globalThis` in sloppy code (→ `undefined` name). It bites with callbacks like `setTimeout(user.regular)`. Fix: `user.regular.bind(user)` or `() => user.regular()`. → §9.1

Q24. How do arrow functions differ from regular functions?

```
Q24 arrow in object literal        "object"
```

	Regular function	Arrow function
`this`	Set by the call	Taken from the surrounding scope (lexical); `call`/`bind` can't change it
`arguments`	Has its own	None (uses the outer one); use rest `...args`
`new`	Can be a constructor	`TypeError` — no `prototype`
Good for	Methods, constructors	Callbacks inside methods

So an arrow used as an object-literal *method* doesn't see the object: its `this` is the outer scope's — here CommonJS's `module.exports`; in an ES module, `undefined`. → §4.3

Q25. Inside a method, what is `this` in a nested regular function vs a nested arrow?

```
delayed() { return [function () { return this === globalThis; }(), (() => this.name)()]; }
```

```
Q25 inner function vs arrow        [ true, 'Ada' ]
```

The inner regular function is called plainly (default `this`: global object in sloppy mode, `undefined` in strict); the arrow inherits the method's `this` — why arrows suit callbacks like `setTimeout(() => this.save(), 100)` inside methods. → §9.1

Q26. What's the difference between `call`, `apply` and `bind`?

```
Q26 call / apply / bind            "Hi Lin! | Yo Lin? | Hey Lin."
```

All three set `this`. `call(thisArg, a, b)` calls now with arguments listed; `apply(thisArg, [a, b])` calls now with an array; `bind(thisArg, a)` **returns a new function** with `this` (and optionally leading arguments) fixed, to call later. Memory aid: **A**pply = **A**rray. → §9.2

Q27. What happens if you `bind` twice?

```
Q27 bind twice                     1
```

The first `bind` wins: a bound function ignores any later `this` from `bind`, `call` or `apply` (the only exception is `new`). → §9.2

Q28. What does `new` do? What if the constructor returns something?

```
Q28 new returns object?            "{\"b\":2}"
Q28 new returns primitive?         "{\"a\":1}"
```

`new F(args)`: (1) creates an empty object whose prototype is `F.prototype`; (2) calls `F` with `this` set to that object; (3) returns that object — **unless** `F` explicitly returns an *object*, which then replaces it. Returned primitives are ignored. → §9.4

17.4.4 Prototypes and classes

Q29. What's the difference between `prototype` and `__proto__`?

```
Q29 proto links                    "true true true"
Q29 own vs inherited               "true false true"
```

Every object has an internal `[[Prototype]]` link (read with `Object.getPrototypeOf`; `__proto__` is the legacy accessor — an old getter/setter property for the same link); missed lookups continue along this **prototype chain**. `F.prototype` is an ordinary property of **functions**: the object `new F()` installs as the instance's `[[Prototype]]`. So methods live on `Animal.prototype` (shared) and data on the instance (`Object.hasOwn(rex, 'speak')` is false, `'speak' in rex` is true). → §9.3

Q30. How does `instanceof` work? Can it be fooled?

```
Q30 instanceof after proto swap    true
```

`x instanceof F` walks `x`'s prototype chain looking for `F.prototype`. It doesn't check how `x` was created, so a plain object whose prototype was set to `Animal.prototype` passes. It also fails across realms (separate JavaScript environments with their own built-ins — an array from an iframe, a page embedded in another, isn't `instanceof Array` here — use `Array.isArray`). → §9.7

Q31. How are classes different from constructor functions?

```
Q31 class before declaration       "ReferenceError: Cannot access 'Later' before initialization"
Q31 class without new              "TypeError: Class constructor K cannot be invoked without 'new'"
```

Mostly syntax over prototypes, but: class declarations are in the TDZ until defined; calling without `new` throws; bodies are strict; methods are non-enumerable; and classes add real features — `#private`, `static` blocks, `super`. → §9.5

Q32. What is `Object.create(null)` for?

```
Q32 Object.create(null)           "undefined true"
```

It creates an object with **no prototype** — no inherited `toString`, `constructor` or `__proto__` — a safe "dictionary" where keys like `'constructor'` from user input can't collide with built-ins. A `Map` is usually the better choice today. → §9.3

Q33. How do `#private` fields compare with closure-based privacy?

```
class Wallet { #cents = 0; add(c) { this.#cents += c; return this.#cents; } }
```

```
Q33 #private vs closure           "10 undefined 0 {}"
```

`#cents` is truly private — invisible to `w.cents`, `Object.keys` and `JSON.stringify`, and a *syntax* error outside the class body. Closure privacy also hides state, but every instance needs its own method copies; `#` fields keep methods shared on the prototype. → §9.5

Q34. What happens if a subclass constructor uses `this` before `super()`?

```
Q34 this before super()           "ReferenceError: Must call super constructor in derived class before accessing
'this' or returning from derived constructor"
```

In a derived class (one that `extends` another) the **parent** constructor creates the object, so `this` doesn't exist until `super(...)` returns. → §9.6

17.4.5 The event loop and async code

For all of these, apply the rules from §12.2–12.3: run all synchronous code first; then drain the **microtask** queue (promise callbacks, code after `await`, `queueMicrotask`) completely; then run **one task** (timer, I/O, event); drain microtasks again; repeat.

Q35. The classic.

```
log('1');
setTimeout(() => log('2'), 0);
Promise.resolve().then(() => log('3'));
log('4');
```

```
Q35 classic                   1 4 3 2
```

`1` and `4` are synchronous. The `.then` callback is a microtask, so it runs as soon as the script finishes; the timer is a task and waits for the next loop turn — even with a 0 ms delay. → §12.2

Q36. `async`/`await` ordering.

```
async function a() { log('a1'); await b(); log('a2'); }
async function b() { log('b'); }
log('s1');
setTimeout(() => log('t'), 0);
a();
new Promise((res) => { log('p'); res(); }).then(() => log('then'));
log('s2');
```

```
Q36 async/await               s1 a1 b p s2 a2 then t
```

An `async` function runs **synchronously until its first** `await` (`a1`, `b`); the rest (`a2`) becomes a microtask. The promise **executor** is synchronous too (`p`). After `s2`, microtasks run in queue order — `a2`, then `then` — and the timer last. → §12.3, §12.9

Q37. `process.nextTick`, promises and `setImmediate` in Node.

```
setImmediate(() => q.push('immediate'));
Promise.resolve().then(() => q.push('then'));
process.nextTick(() => q.push('nextTick'));
q.push('sync');
```

```
Q37 CommonJS main                 sync nextTick then immediate
Q37 ESM (after await)          sync then nextTick immediate
```

Node normally drains `nextTick` **before** promise microtasks (the CommonJS result). Inside an ES module (here after a top-level `await`) the code already runs in a promise job, so promises drain first. `setImmediate` runs later, in the *check* phase. Don't rely on the `nextTick`/promise order; prefer `queueMicrotask`. → §12.4

Q38. When does a promise executor run, and what if you resolve twice?

```
Q38 executor + settle once     executor after first
```

The function passed to `new Promise(...)` runs **synchronously**, right away. A promise settles **once**: the first `resolve`/`reject` wins, later calls are ignored silently. → §12.7

Q39. Why doesn't this `try`/`catch` catch the error?

```
try { setTimeout(() => { throw new Error('boom'); }, 0); } catch { /* never runs */ }
try { await Promise.reject(new Error('rejected')); } catch (e) { /* runs */ }
```

```
Q39 errors in callbacks        uncaught: boom | await caught: rejected
```

`try` only covers code running *while it's on the stack*. The timer callback runs later, so its error is uncaught (the demo shows it via `process.on('uncaughtException')`; normally Node would crash). With `await`, the rejection is thrown back into the function at the `await`, so `try`/`catch` works. → §11.5, §12.10

Q40. Does `await` inside `forEach` wait?

```
[20, 10].forEach(async (ms) => { await wait(ms); log.push(ms); });
log.push('forEach returned');
for (const ms of [20, 10]) { await wait(ms); log.push(`for-of ${ms}`); }
```

```
Q40 await in forEach           forEach returned | 10 | 20 | for-of 20 | for-of 10
```

No. `forEach` ignores the promise each async callback returns, so it returns immediately and callbacks finish in timer order. Use `for…of` + `await` for sequential work, `await Promise.all(arr.map(async …))` for parallel. → §12.9

Q41. Two independent `await`s — how long do they take?

```
Q41 sequential vs parallel     sequential >= 80ms: true, parallel < 80ms: true
```

`await wait(40); await wait(40);` takes ~80 ms because the second doesn't start until the first finishes. Starting both and awaiting `Promise.all([...])` takes ~40 ms. Start independent work first, await later. → §12.9

Q42. `Promise.all` vs `allSettled` vs `race` vs `any`?

Combinator	Fulfils when	Rejects when
`all`	All fulfil (array of values, input order)	The first rejection
`allSettled`	All settle (array of `{status, value/reason}`)	Never
`race`	The first to settle fulfils	The first to settle rejects
`any`	The first fulfils	All reject (`AggregateError`)

Implementations and tests: §17.3. → §12.8

17.4.6 Objects, arrays and copies

Q43. Shallow vs deep copy — what does this print?

```
const a = { n: { v: 1 } }; const b = { ...a }; b.n.v = 2; a.n.v;
```

```
Q43 spread copy is shallow        2
```

Spread copies only the top level; `b.n` and `a.n` are the same nested object. For a deep copy use `structuredClone` (or the manual clone, §17.3). → §5.4

Q44. Can you change a `const` object? Does `Object.freeze` make it immutable?

```
Q44 const + mutate                2
Q44 freeze is shallow             "2 undefined"
```

`const` protects the **binding**, not the object. `Object.freeze` blocks adding, removing and changing *own* properties (silently in sloppy mode, `TypeError` in strict) but is **shallow** — nested objects stay mutable; deep-freeze by recursing. → §5.6

Q45. What happens when you use an object as an object key?

```
const o = {}; o[{}] = 'a'; o[{ id: 2 }] = 'b'; o[1] = 'c';
```

```
Q45 object keys become strings    "[\"1\",\"[object Object]\"] b"
```

Property keys are strings (or symbols). Both objects convert to the same string `"[object Object]"`, so the second assignment overwrites the first; `1` becomes `"1"`. Use a `Map` for object keys. → §5.2, §8.1

Q46. What do `delete arr[i]` and `arr.length = n` do?

```
Q46 array holes                   "3 [1,null,3] false"
Q46 length truncates              "[1]"
Q46 length of sparse              6
```

`delete` removes the element but leaves a **hole** — the length stays 3 (JSON shows the hole as `null`). Use `splice` to remove. Setting `length` smaller truncates the array (`arr.length = 0` empties it in place). Assigning `a[5]` on an empty array makes `length` 6 with five holes. → §7.3

Q47. Is JavaScript pass-by-value or pass-by-reference?

```
const o = { v: 1 };
(function (p) { p = { v: 99 }; })(o);   // reassign the parameter
(function (p) { p.v = 2; })(o);          // mutate through it
o.v;
```

```
Q47 reassign param                2
```

Always **by value** — but an object's value *is a reference* ("call by sharing"): mutating through the parameter changes the caller's object; reassigning it changes only the local variable. → §2.4

Q48. When should you use a `Map` instead of an object?

Use a `Map` for dynamic keys added and removed at runtime, non-string keys, frequent size checks and guaranteed insertion order; use a plain object for fixed-shape records (a user, a config) and JSON. Objects also have inherited keys (`'toString' in {}` is true) — a source of bugs with user-supplied keys. → §7.8, §8.1

Q49. What does `JSON.stringify` drop?

```
Q49 JSON drops                    "{\"n\":null,\"d\":\"1970-01-01T00:00:00.000Z\"}"
Q49 JSON array holes              "[null,null]"
```

Object properties holding `undefined`, a function or a symbol are **omitted** (in arrays they become `null`); `NaN`/`Infinity` → `null`; dates → ISO strings (the standard `2026-01-15T10:00:00.000Z` format); `Map`/`Set` → `{}`; `BigInt` and cycles throw. → §5.12

Q50. `for…in` vs `for…of`?

```
Q50 for...in vs for...of          "in: 0,1,extra | of: a,b"
```

`for…in` loops over **enumerable property keys** (strings; enumerable = visible to loops, which ordinary properties are), including inherited ones and extras like `extra` — meant for plain objects. `for…of` loops over the **values** of any *iterable*; use it for arrays. → §3.10

17.4.7 Garbage collection and memory leaks

Q51. How does JavaScript free memory?

Automatically, with a **garbage collector (GC)**. An object stays alive while it is **reachable** from a *root* (globals, the call stack, active closures, pending callbacks). Unreachable objects are freed even if they reference each other — **mark-and-sweep** marks everything reachable and sweeps the rest, so cycles are fine. V8 is **generational**: a small *young generation* is collected often and cheaply (most objects die young), survivors move to an *old generation* collected less often, much of it on helper threads. Normal code can't (and needn't) trigger GC. → §8.3

Q52. What causes memory leaks in JavaScript, and how do you fix them?

A **leak** is memory that is still reachable but no longer needed. The usual causes:

Cause	Example	Fix
Forgotten listeners and timers	`setInterval` or `addEventListener` never removed; the callback's closure keeps data alive	`clearInterval`, `removeEventListener`, `AbortController` signal, React effect cleanup
Unbounded caches and collections	A `Map` from request/DOM objects to data that only grows	Size limit (LRU), or a `WeakMap` keyed by the object
Closures capturing big data	A long-lived callback references a huge array it doesn't need	Copy only what's needed into the closure; set big references to `null`
Detached DOM nodes	A removed element still referenced from a JS variable or array	Drop the reference when the element is removed
Accidental globals	`x = …` without declaration (sloppy mode)	Strict mode / modules

The demo stores ~8 KB of data per short-lived "request" object in a `Map` and in a `WeakMap`, then forces a GC (only possible with a V8 flag, used here for the demonstration):

```
Q52 Map vs WeakMap cache          Map retains > 10 MB: true, WeakMap retains < 2 MB: true
```

The `Map` keeps every key object and its data alive forever; the `WeakMap` lets both be collected once the request object is unreachable. Find leaks with DevTools' **Memory** panel: take heap snapshots (a dump of every object in memory at that moment) before and after an action and compare what grew. → §4.7, §8.3, §11.9

Q53. What are `WeakMap`, `WeakRef` and `FinalizationRegistry` for?

```
Q53 WeakRef before                true
Q53 WeakRef after gc              collected
```

`WeakMap`/`WeakSet` hold keys **weakly** — an entry vanishes with its key, ideal for metadata or caches on objects you don't own. A `WeakRef` points to an object without keeping it alive (`deref()` → the object or `undefined`); `FinalizationRegistry` calls back some time after collection. GC timing is **not guaranteed**, so use these only for optional optimisations, never program logic. → §8.3

In the interview

> **30-second answer — "`this`, closures and the event loop in one breath?"** `this` comes from the call site (method, plain call, `new`, `call` / `apply` / `bind`) except in arrows, which take it lexically. A closure is a function plus its creation scope's variables, kept alive with it. The event loop runs sync code, then all microtasks, then one task, repeat — so promise callbacks beat `setTimeout(0)`.

Self-check

1. `console.log([] + null + 1)`? → `"null1"`: `[]` becomes `''`, then string concatenation.
2. Why does `for (var i…) setTimeout(() => console.log(i))` print the final value? → One shared `var` binding; `let` creates one per iteration.
3. In `async function f() { console.log(1); await null; console.log(2); } f(); console.log(3);` — the order? → `1 3 2`.
4. `typeof typeof 1`? → `'string'` (`typeof 1` is the string `'number'`).
5. Does `Object.freeze` stop `obj.nested.x = 1`? → No, freeze is shallow.

TL;DR

Use `===`; know the falsy list, `typeof null`, `NaN` rules and how `+` concatenates. `var` is function-scoped and hoisted as `undefined`; `let` / `const` are block-scoped with a TDZ; `let` in loops gives one binding per iteration. `this` depends on the call; arrows inherit it; `bind` wins once; `new` returns the new object unless you return an object. Classes are prototypes plus TDZ, strictness and `#private`. Sync → microtasks → one task. Spread is shallow; `structuredClone` is deep. Leaks come from things that stay reachable — listeners, timers, caches, closures; `WeakMap` and cleanup fix them.

Chapter 17 TL;DR

- **Toolkit:** `push` / `pop` stack; head-index queue (no `shift` in hot loops); `Array.from` grids; `Map` / `Set` with string keys for pairs; `sort` needs a comparator, is stable, mutates (`toSorted` doesn't); floats — tolerance, `Math.trunc`, `%` sign, safe to $2^{53} - 1$, then `BigInt`; build strings with `join`.
- **Patterns (21):** two pointers, sliding window, hashing, stack/monotonic stack, prefix sums, intervals (sort + sweep), heap (hand-written `MinHeap`, O(log n) push/pop; two heaps for a running median; k-way merge), binary search (on data or the answer), BFS (fewest steps, mark on enqueue), DFS (iterative for deep inputs), DP with memo, backtracking (choose/explore/un-choose, copy results), linked lists (dummy head, reverse, k-th from end), fast & slow pointers (cycle start, middle), trees (validate with ranges, LCA, serialize), tries (prefix, wildcard, board words), Kahn's topological sort and union-find, greedy (with a proof), quickselect / Dutch flag / merge sort, bit manipulation (32-bit signed, `>>> 0`), math & geometry (spiral, overflow, gcd-reduced slopes).
- **Classics:** `debounce` (clear + restart a timer) vs `throttle` (at most once per interval, leading + trailing); `curry` via `fn.length`; `compose` = `reduceRight`, `pipe` = `reduce`; `memoize` with a `Map`; `flatten` recursive or with a stack; `bind` must support `new`; `structuredClone` vs manual `deepClone` with a `WeakMap`; `deepEqual` with `Object.is`; LRU = one `Map`; EventEmitter copies listeners before emitting; `Promise.all` = index + counter + `Promise.resolve` + empty case.
- **Q&A:** coercion and `==` rules, `typeof null`, `NaN`, `??` vs `||`; hoisting and TDZ, closures in loops, accidental globals, strict mode; `this` rules, arrows, `call` / `apply` / `bind`, `new`; prototype chain, `instanceof`, classes vs functions, `#private`; event-loop order (sync → microtasks → task), `nextTick`, errors in callbacks, `await` in `forEach`, parallel awaits; shallow vs deep copy, `freeze`, keys as strings, holes, call by sharing, JSON; GC by reachability, leaks and weak references.

Next: the cheat sheets and glossary — Chapter 18.